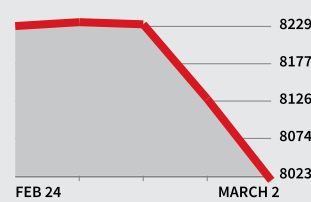


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 80238.85 (-1048.34)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24865.70	-312.95
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	22.03	-0.29
US Dollar (in ₹)	91.47	+0.50
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	166800.00	+8340
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	289848.00	+23148

SECURITY IN FOCUS.

The Amazon UAE data centre disruption during the US-Iran conflict underscores growing focus on strengthening security and resiliency **p10**



ORDERS BOOST.

Manufacturing PMI rose to a 4-month high of 56.9 in February on strong domestic orders **p7**

BENGALURU - CHENNAI - COIMBATORE - HUBBALLI - HYDERABAD - KOCHI - KOLKATA - MADURAI - MALAPPURAM - MANGALURU - MUMBAI - NOIDA - THIRUVANANTHAPURAM - TIRUCHIRAPPALLI - VIJAYAWADA - VISAKHAPATNAM

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QUICKLY.

THREE-MONTH LOW
January factory output growth slows to 4.8%



New Delhi: With manufacturing and mining showing subdued performance, growth of factory output, based on the Index of Industrial Production, dipped to a three-month low 4.8 per cent in January, per Statistics Ministry data. Industrial production growth for December was revised to 8 per cent from the provisional 7.8 per cent released in January. **p7**

STABLE RETURNS

EPF interest rate retained at 8.25% for FY26

New Delhi: The Employees' Provident Fund Organisation on Monday decided to retain the interest rate on employees' provident fund deposits at 8.25 per cent for FY26, as the government says it has been able to maintain strong financial discipline despite global uncertainties. The EPF interest rate was raised to 8.25 per cent for FY24, up from 8.15 per cent in 2022-23, and from then it has remain constant. **p9**

US/Israel-Iran conflict rattles financial markets, trade corridors

IN THE RED. Bullion surges; crude rises; cargo flows, including of agri products, disrupted

Our Bureaus

Mumbai/New Delhi/Chennai

The ongoing war involving Iran, the US and Israel sent shockwaves through India's financial markets and trade corridors on Monday, weakening the rupee past the 91-mark against the dollar, triggering the steepest fall in benchmark equities in weeks, hardening crude and gold prices, and disrupting cargo flows across air and sea routes.

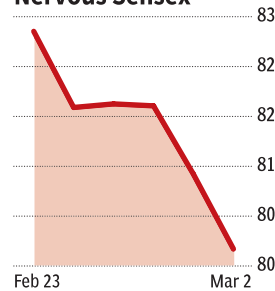
As risk-off sentiment gripped investors and shipping lines imposed steep war-related surcharges, the government convened urgent consultations to assess the fallout on exports, imports and supply chains.

RE AT 1-MONTH LOW

The rupee touched a one-month low, opening at 91.25 per dollar, 28 paise weaker than the previous close of 90.97, and testing an intraday range of 91.2150 to 91.4900 before closing at 91.47, down 50 paise. The Reserve Bank of India is believed to have intervened to prevent a sharper slide.

Market meltdown

Nervous Sensex



Equity benchmarks mirrored the anxiety. The BSE Sensex closed at 80,238.85, down 1,048.34 points after opening sharply lower at 78,543.73. The NSE Nifty 50 ended at 24,865.70, declining 312.95 points after hitting an intraday low near 24,600.

GOLD, SILVER RISE

Safe-haven demand drove precious metals higher. Gold topped \$5,375 an ounce globally, while silver nearly touched \$95 before easing. In Mumbai's spot market, gold jumped ₹8,374 to ₹1,67,471 per 10 g from ₹1,59,097 over the weekend.

Trade and logistics chan-



War-driven shutdown of Dubai, Doha and Abu Dhabi airports for a third day threw global air travel into disarray, stranding tens of thousands **REUTERS**

nels felt immediate strain. Shipping lines imposed 'Emergency Conflict and War Risk' surcharges ranging from \$1,500 to \$4,000 per container for cargo to and from Arabian Peninsula ports, with some carriers suspending bookings.

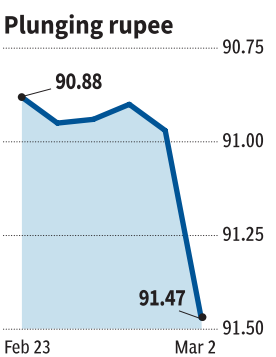
Air cargo was also disrupted; about 450 tonnes meant for West Asia/Gulf carriers were stranded at Chennai alone, while 13 incoming Middle East commercial flights were cancelled there. The Bengaluru airport reported 72 cancellations.

EXPORTERS TAKE A HIT

Basmati shipments to West Asia have been disrupted,

with 60,000-70,000 tonnes on the high seas, some near Bandar Abbas. In April-January 2025-26, basmati exports had risen 11 per cent year-on-year to 5.38 million tonnes. Cashew exporters reported shipments worth hundreds of crores stranded, while pistachio prices rose by ₹100 per kg amid disrupted Iranian supplies.

India Ratings and Research warned that a prolonged closure of the Strait of Hormuz could raise freight costs by 3-5 per cent, up insurance premiums by 0.1-0.5 per cent, lengthen voyage times and escalate working capital pressures. Chief Economist Devendra



Pant cautioned that remittances could also be affected if the conflict persists.

As Brent crude, the global benchmark, climbed close to \$80/barrel, Indian refiners may tap Russian barrels floating in the Indian Ocean and the Arabian Sea.

URGENT MEETING

The Department of Commerce held an urgent stakeholder consultation on Monday to assess the disruptions. Chaired by Special Secretary Suchindra Misra and DGFT Lav Agarwal, the meeting discussed mechanisms for facilitation of time-sensitive export segments.

More reports p2,p3,p8,p10

Air India reroutes flights to maintain West connectivity

Rohit Vaid

New Delhi

ternative corridors on Monday.

NETWORK PLANNING

A senior airline official told *businessline* that the network planning team had "war-gamed multiple conflict scenarios" and identified viable alternatives in the event of restricted Gulf airspace.

According to sources, Europe, the US and Canada-bound services are being routed via airspace over the Red Sea, Saudi Arabia, Egypt and the Mediterranean to bypass constrained zones. These adjustments add 30-45 minutes to the flying time that Air India flights were taking until February 28.

TECHNICAL HALTS

For services to the US and Canada, Air India has incorporated technical halts in Rome and Vienna for refuelling before onward trans-Atlantic operations, with the Rome halt implemented from Monday onwards.

However, the new flight paths have cost implications. European services are operating with 30-45 minutes of additional flying time on average. Flights to Canada and the US are expected to see fare increases of 10-15 per cent, with total journey times rising by two hours depending on routing and technical halt requirements.

Modi, Canadian PM Carney re-set ties; sign 5 MoUs including on uranium, key minerals

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India and Canada agreed to fast-track negotiations on the long-discussed bilateral free trade agreement targeting a year-end conclusion, double bilateral trade to \$50 billion by 2030 and signed a major \$(Canadian) 2.6 billion (\$1.9 billion) uranium deal as Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Canadian counterpart Mark Carney discussed taking relations to the "next level partnership" on Monday.

FTA BY YEAR-END

"We are advancing towards an India-Canada comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA) with the aim to conclude it by the end of this year. This ambi-



BONHOMIE IS BACK. Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney, in New Delhi **PTI**

tious agreement will reduce barriers, increase certainty, unlock opportunity for exporters, investors and workers in both our countries with the objective of doubling trade by the end of this decade," Carney said in his statement at the joint press meet with Modi in Delhi.

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and his Canadian counterpart Maninder Sidhu

signed the terms of reference for the CEPA providing the format, frequency and approach to the negotiations.

In their joint statement, Modi and Carney welcomed the conclusion of a \$(CAD) 2.6 billion commercial agreement between Cameco and the Department of Atomic Energy for the long-term supply of uranium, contributing to India's civil nuclear

energy generation, clean energy transition objectives and long-term energy security. "In civil nuclear energy, we have signed a landmark deal for long-term uranium supply. We will also work together on small modular reactors and advanced reactors," Modi said.

FIVE PACTS

Five memorandums of understanding (MoUs) were exchanged, covering cooperation in critical minerals (lithium and rare earths), renewable energy, and the establishment of an India-Canada Defence Dialogue. A declaration of intent to establish a 'Joint Pulse Protein Centre of Excellence' was also signed.

The two leaders also discussed securing supply chains for critical minerals.

Amaravati gearing to receive its elite residents

From a ghost town to a power centre, the new AP capital is readying to fulfil its dream

G Naga Sridhar
Vijayawada

Amaravati, the new capital of Andhra Pradesh, is all set to welcome a set of influential residents.

MLAs, senior bureaucrats and judges, who are currently living in rented premises in Vijayawada, will soon move into their official homes in the new capital. From a near-deserted stretch of scrubland just two years ago, Amaravati has transformed into a bustling hive of activity as it races towards its dream of becoming a power centre.

The tree lined avenues look welcoming. There are smart signs indicating new buildings coming up and connecting roads to the highways.

JUDGES ENCLAVE

On Sunday, the Chief Justice of India formally inaugurated a residential enclave of judges, comprising



POWER HOUSE. MLAs, senior bureaucrats and judges will soon move into their official homes in the new capital

36 villas. Two residential apartment towers and individual bungalows for senior bureaucrats and ministers are nearing completion.

The units are expected to be handed over to the government officials in a phased manner in the coming months.

At present, many officials commute weekly between Hyderabad and Vijayawada. In the State Secretariat, Fridays are informally dubbed 'Hyderabad Day', as a large number of employees travel to their homes in Hydera-

bad, returning to work on Monday mornings.

RELAUNCH OF WORKS

Amaravati already houses a functional Secretariat, Assembly and the Andhra Pradesh High Court, built during the 2014-19 tenure of the Telugu Desam Party government led by N Chandrababu Naidu.

Construction of other administrative buildings and residential complexes was halted midway after the YSR Congress Party government under YS Jagan

Mohan Reddy proposed shifting the executive capital away from Amaravati.

Following its return to power, the NDA government resumed the stalled works. Coming up rapidly is the General Administration Department Tower, a 49-storey structure (excluding the basement and ground floor), while the Heads of Departments Tower will rise 39 storeys high.

According to a senior official of the Amaravati Growth and Infrastructure Corporation, work is advancing on schedule to meet the Chief Minister's deadline of finishing the infrastructure of the new capital by 2029.

The State government has awarded contracts worth ₹50,000 crore to various companies for projects in the region. Currently, 10,000 workers from different States are engaged in construction activity across Amaravati.

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QUICKLY.

Oil stocks shield China's refiners from Iran war



A hoard of Iranian oil on tankers at sea, and swelling onshore inventories in China, will provide an initial cushion for the world's biggest importer from the fallout of the conflict in West Asia. There's over 46 million barrels of Iranian crude in Asia, with close to 80 per cent of the ships anchored in the Singapore Strait and off the Chinese coast, per Kpler Ltd. China also stockpiled crude at onshore sites over the past year. **BLOOMBERG**

Russia, Ukraine hope for US-led peace talks

Russia and Ukraine still expect planned US-led peace talks to take place this week, even as the US continues a military campaign against Iran. With airspace in the UAE closed amid the risk of missile and drone attacks, the talks are unlikely to take place in Abu Dhabi, said a person in the know in Moscow. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Monday said the talks that were planned for March 5-6 in Abu Dhabi haven't yet been cancelled. Turkey and Switzerland could be alternative locations, he said. **BLOOMBERG**

Commerce Dept, stakeholders meet to ease trade disruptions

ON THE TABLE. Surging freight costs, insurance premium, logistical challenges discussed

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

The Commerce Department held an urgent stakeholder consultation on Monday to assess the disruptions triggered by the escalating Iran crisis and the broader West Asian conflict and its impact on India's exports and imports.

Stakeholders discussed mechanisms for facilitation of time-sensitive export segments such as perishables, pharmaceuticals, and high-value manufactured exports in the meeting chaired by Special Secretary Suchindra Misra and DGFT Lav Agarwal. It was attended by exporters from various sectors and representatives from key ministries and departments, including financial services, petroleum & natural gas and ports, shipping & waterways.

TRANSIT IN QUESTION Officials from the Central Board of Indirect Taxes & Customs and the RBI, as well as some logistics partners, were also present, per a statement issued by the Commerce Department. "Stakeholders presented an assessment of the evolving operational environment, including routing and transit-time changes, vessel scheduling adjust-



AIR TIGHT. The Apparel Exporters Promotion Council wrote to the Civil Aviation Secretary seeking waiver of demurrage charges on export cargo due to flight disruptions **REUTERS**

ments, container/equipment availability, freight and insurance cost trends, and implications for time-sensitive exports. The discussions covered the need to maintain predictability in cargo movement, minimise avoidable delays, and ensure seamless documentation and payment processes for exporters and importers," the statement noted.

Discussions focussed on the fallout of the crisis, such as surging freight costs and insurance premiums, and the logistical challenges of rerouting cargo away from

the Strait of Hormuz. "Considering the narrow margins under which textile and apparel exporters operate, any escalation in the cost of logistics and insurance due to the West Asia scenario puts them in a very tight spot, affecting their ability to meet contractual obligations besides significantly raising operating costs," said Ashwin Chandran, Chairperson, Confederation of Indian Textile Industry.

SEEKING COVER The Apparel Exporters Promotion Council (AEPCC)

wrote to the Civil Aviation Secretary seeking waiver of demurrage charges on export cargo due to flight disruptions arising from the ongoing crisis.

"The prevailing situation has significantly disrupted international flight operations, resulting in route restrictions, airspace closures, flight diversions, schedule irregularities, and operational constraints at certain overseas airports...As a result, export consignments are currently stranded at multiple airport cargo terminals across India. The delays are solely attributable to external and unforeseen factors beyond the control of exporters, customs brokers, freight forwarders, or air cargo agents," A Sakthivel, Chairman, AEPCC, wrote in the letter, per a statement.

In the meeting, government officials assured exporters that it was the country's priority to ensure continuity of EXIM logistics and mitigate any disruptions to India's trade flows. It was emphasised that the approach will remain facilitative and coordinated, with a focus on maintaining supply chain resilience, protecting the interests of exporters — particularly MSMEs — with a view that essential imports required for domestic production and consumption are not adversely affected.

Closure of Strait of Hormuz to push India towards floating Russian crude

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

As a higher percentage of West Asian supplies in India's current crude oil import mix exacerbates its sensitivity to even short-term disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz, Indian refiners can opt for Russian barrels that are currently floating in the Indian Ocean and Arabian Sea region.

businessline spoke with government officials, refiners and traders, who said Indian refiners can tap into Russian oil cargoes idling in the Arabian Sea.

Sources said Indian public and private sector refiners are already procuring non-sanctioned Russian crude oil.

However, if the closure of the Strait of Hormuz is extended or the conflict intensifies with attacks on oil and gas infrastructure in the Middle East Gulf (MEG) region, domestic refiners will have to manage supplies from "anywhere possible".

"In such a scenario, Russian crude at sea is among the best possible alternatives. Supplies from the US, South America and West Africa will take anywhere between 30 and 45 days, which can be an issue if this war extends further," said a government source.

COMING FULL CIRCLE Global real-time data and analytics provider Kpler also pointed out that in a scenario



CHOPPY WATERS. Sources said that the government will stop exports of petroleum products, particularly diesel, petrol and jet fuel, if domestic supplies get stretched **REUTERS**

where West Asian imports become constrained or show signs of disruption, Indian refiners, potentially with policy backing, could pivot back to Russian cargoes relatively quickly.

Another important consideration is the availability of Russian crude. A significant number of Russian barrels are currently floating in the Indian Ocean and the Arabian Sea region, partly due to reduced Indian imports over the past few months. These floating volumes effectively act as a near-term optional supply, explained Sumit Ritolia, Kpler's Lead Research Analyst for Refining & Modeling.

Moody's Analytics on Monday said: "The conflict also complicates matters for India, which imports large amounts of West Asian oil and has agreed to wind down purchases of Russian oil as part of a trade deal with the US — a deal which now sits in a limbo after the US Supreme Court struck down US President Donald

Trump's country-based tariffs."

STOP ON EXPORTS? On Monday, Oil Minister Hardeep S Puri reviewed India's supply situation for crude oil, liquefied natural gas (LNG), liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and other petroleum products with senior officials from the Ministry and oil PSUs.

"We are continuously monitoring the evolving situation, and all necessary steps will be taken in order to ensure availability and affordability of major petroleum products in the country," the Oil Ministry said on X. Sources said that the government will stop exports of petroleum products, particularly diesel, petrol and jet fuel if domestic supplies get stretched. It is also constantly in touch with the PSU oil marketing companies (OMCs) on the LPG supply situation, considering West Asia accounts for the majority of the imports of the key cooking fuel.

Auto parts sector sees delay in supply to EU

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Even though India's automobile companies have stated that vehicle exports have not significantly taken a hit due to the Iran-Israel war, the components sector has noted potential delays in supplies of auto parts to the European Union (EU).

This is due to several ships being anchored near the Red Sea or being ordered to return to port.

"While the crisis in Middle East and rising crude prices may create some near-term cost pressures, the industry today is far more resilient and better prepared to manage volatility. Demand fundamentals remain strong, and we expect growth momentum to continue. At the same time, we will continue to closely monitor geopolitical developments and global energy trends that could impact the sector," Vinnie Mehta, Director General of the Automotive Component Manufacturers Association



UNDER WATCH. The sector continues to follow the developments as well as global energy trends, said an expert

(ACMA) of India, told businessline.

With countries and stakeholders taking stock of the situation, shipments through the Strait of Hormuz have been ceased; shipments to Dubai are yet to be offloaded, and ships are either anchored, asked to be turned back, or have offloaded and remain anchored there, he added.

Another industry official noted that freight and insurance costs are bound to rise — all of which must be factored in at the final port. "We also

have to meet the timelines for export or else vehicle production suffers. You have to go through the Red Sea, Suez Canal, and reach Europe, and now you have to take a longer route; cost will go up and [it is a] challenging situation for availability of containers too," he added.

DIVERSE PORTFOLIO Rahul Bharti, Senior Executive Officer of Corporate Affairs at Maruti Suzuki India (MSIL), said the company is "closely monitoring the situation". MSIL is the largest

exporter of vehicles from India, serving approximately 100 countries. However, he also noted that MSIL's exposure to Middle East as an export region is not very high. "This year, for example, it accounts for about 12.5 per cent of our total exports. In fact, as we export to nearly 100 countries, we have ensured that our portfolio is well diversified and inherently derisked... We are not just increasing exports, we are expanding them in a broad-based manner, ensuring that we remain de-risked at the same time," Bharti added.

VEHICLE EXPORTS Another industry official mentioned there is currently little impact on vehicle exports from India due to the Iran-Israel war. "We do export some vehicles to Saudi Arabia, but those are not in great numbers, so the impact is less. Our markets in South Africa and Latin America are different for which routes are different," he added.

QatarEnergy halting LNG production may impact India's gas consumption

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The decision to stop liquefied natural gas (LNG) production by QatarEnergy — which accounts for roughly one-fifth of global trade — could lead to a decline in demand for the commodity by price sensitive Indian buyers.

The world's fourth-largest LNG importer bought 35.72 billion standard cubic meters (BSCM) of the super chilled commodity in FY25 for \$14.9 billion, of which 40-42 per cent was from Qatar.

On Monday, QatarEnergy said, "Due to military attacks on QatarEnergy's operating facilities in Ras Laffan Industrial City and Mesaieed Industrial City in the State of Qatar, QatarEnergy has ceased production of LNG and associated products. QatarEnergy values its relationships with all of its stakeholders and will continue to communicate the latest



available information."

QatarEnergy's 77 million tonne per annum (mtpa) export facility at Ras Laffan is among the world's largest. The news has already rattled markets with European benchmark gas futures surging to multi-year highs.

ASIA HEAVY The development also assumes importance as the majority of QatarEnergy's clients are Asian economies, including India. Global LNG supplies are already facing pressure due to closure of the Strait of Hormuz and the

expected retaliation by Iran in response to the killing of its supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in a joint US-Israel offensive on Saturday.

Sehul Bhatt, Director at Crisil Intelligence, said that developments in West Asia could increase pricing and procurement risks for crude oil and LNG, posing substantial challenges for India, which have more than 85 per cent and 50 per cent import dependency, respectively, in these items.

Sustained disruptions would keep crude prices elevated and tighten LNG availability underscoring the need for strategic planning to protect India's energy security, he added.

TRADE-OFF India reduces its consumption of the super chilled commodity if the prices are on the higher side. A price range of \$6-8 per million British thermal units (mBtu) is considered a safe bet.

As global LNG supply ex-

pands, India is already positioning itself as a benchmark-driven swing buyer — selectively accessing spot and short-term cargoes when international price markers align with domestic alternatives.

In January 2026, Kenneth Foo, Global Director for LNG price reporting at S&P Global Energy, said, "As global LNG supply growth accelerates, India is increasingly a benchmark-driven swing buyer, stepping into the spot or short-term markets during dislocations between (West India Marker) WIM vs Henry Hub vs Brent linked-pricing."

India imported just under 26 mtpa of LNG in 2025. An additional 3.5-4 mtpa of long-term contracted volumes is set to start delivering from 2026. Higher term supply leaves limited scope for spot LNG in 2026, especially if prices remain uncompetitive versus propane, naphtha and fuel oil, he pointed out.

Consumer durables, FMCG companies stare at heightened cost pressures amid rising conflict

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The conflict in West Asia has started mounting input cost pressures on consumer product companies. Consumer appliance players expect escalating crude oil prices and freight cost to increase input cost pressures.

FMCG companies are also concerned about an increase in packaging cost. Analysts noted that exports to Gulf economies, which include electronics and food products, face shipment risks and demand uncertainty if volatility persists.

Kamal Nandi, Business Head & EVP at Appliances Business of Godrej Enterprises Group, said: "Higher oil prices drive up the cost of essential raw materials such



LOGISTICS ISSUES. FMCG companies anticipate an impact on costs due to increase in freight and packaging prices **ISTOCKPHOTO**

as polypropylene, styrene monomer and ABS, which are fundamental to the manufacturing of refrigerators, washing machines, air conditioners and other appliances. While we are closely monitoring the situation and the potential for further logistics and supply chain disruptions, our focus remains on optimising internal efficiencies to absorb these shocks as much as possible. However, if the upward trajectory of crude and the weakening of the rupee persist, it will put pressure on consumer pricing in the near term."

Avneet Singh Marwah, CEO, SPPL said, "TV and smartphone makers are already facing RAM short-

age. The West Asian conflict is adversely impacting freight costs amid rupee depreciation leading to increased production costs. This will lead to a hike in prices for consumers."

FACILITIES ABROAD FMCG companies also anticipate an impact on costs due to increase in freight and packaging prices. West Asia serves as one of the key export markets for many Indian FMCG companies, with some of them also having manufacturing facilities located in the region.

Mayank Shah, Vice-President, Parle Products, said, "We have a manufacturing facility in

Bahrain. Production is running as usual. Also, any volatility in crude oil prices leads to higher packaging costs for the FMCG sector, besides concerns around higher freight costs."

Naveen Malpani, Partner and Consumer and Retail Industry Leader, Grant Thornton Bharat, noted that an elevated crude directly increases packaging, freight, fuel and other input costs, compressing margins unless offset by pricing power or hedging.

"Higher freight and insurance costs are delaying shipments and raising export logistics expenses, impacting segments from textiles to engineering goods. India's \$45-50 billion of non-oil exports to Gulf economies, including electronics, chemicals, food products and gems, face shipment risk and demand uncertainty if volatility persists," he added.

Meanwhile, Pankaj Mohindroo, Chairman, ICEA, said any disruption in key trade corridors can create logistical challenges as "geopolitical choke points" can raise logistics costs and extend transit times, particularly if instability persists.

Edible oil sector turns cautious amid Iran crisis; oilmeals shipments may be hit

AJ Vinayak
Mangaluru

Edible oil and oilmeals sectors in India are in a wait-and-watch mode following the situation arising from the US-Israel attacks on Iran. However, shipments of oilmeals to the Gulf and Europe could take a hit.

BV Mehta, Executive Director of the Solvent Extractors' Association of India (SEA), told businessline that India's edible oil supply is significantly dependent on imports. Palm oil is sourced primarily from Indonesia and Malaysia, while soybean oil is imported from Argentina, Brazil, and the US, and sunflower oil from Russia and Ukraine.

A substantial portion of these shipments transit through the Strait of Hormuz and Suez Canal. Any disruption of this critical maritime route could lead to short-term volatility in availability and prices, particularly for sunflower oil. Further, an increase in global crude oil prices may lead to higher freight and insurance costs, both internationally



INFLATIONARY IMPACT. In addition to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, any further increase in global crude oil prices may lead to higher freight and insurance costs **REUTERS**

and domestically. This could raise the landed cost of edible oils and exert pressure on domestic prices. At this stage, however, the situation remains dynamic and requires close monitoring, Mehta said.

Sudhakar Desai, President, Indian Vegetable Oil Producers' Association (IVPA), said that any escalation between the US and Iran has a direct ripple effect on India's crude and edible oil markets. Rising crude oil

prices not only increase logistics costs but also create inflationary impact on global prices due to the linkage between edible and global biofuel markets, and it can also increase the insurance risks of the vessels.

"Given, India's heavy dependence on imported edible oils, these global supply chain disruptions will have impact on prices in India," he said. In terms of supply chain, especially for sunflower and soybean oils,

there can be disruptions if there are problems around Red Sea area and the straits, especially from Black Sea area, Desai said, adding, "in the near term, we expect volatility to persist both in oils and also on dollar/INR prices with central focus on these geopolitical wars".

SEA data showed that India imported 38.78 lakh tonnes (lt) of edible oils during the first three months of November-January of the oil year 2025-26 (November-October) against 39.21 lt in the corresponding period of the previous oil year. Of this, the share of sunflower oil 7.62 lt during November-January of the oil year 2025-26.

OILMEALS On the export side, India exports oilmeals largely to South-East Asia (approximately 65 per cent), West Asia (around 20 per cent) and Europe (about 15 per cent). If the conflict persists or escalates, trade flows to West Asia and Europe may face logistical and demand-side disruptions, potentially impacting export volumes and realisations, Mehta said.

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CM YK

QUICKLY.

No sign of strikes on nuclear sites: IAEA

Vienna: The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) has no indication Israeli and US attacks on Iran have hit any nuclear facilities, its chief Rafael Grossi told the agency's Board of Governors on Monday, despite Iran's envoy stating one was targeted a day earlier. Iran's ambassador to the IAEA, Reza Najafi, told reporters outside the closed door meeting that the sprawling nuclear complex at Natanz had been attacked. REUTERS

China denies supersonic missiles deal with Iran

Beijing: China on Monday denied reports of finalising a deal with Iran to sell CM-302 supersonic anti-ship missiles before the joint US-Israeli airstrikes on the country. If delivered, the missiles would be among the most advanced military hardware to be transferred to Iran by China in recent years, according to media reports. PTI

Iran conflict escalates, spills over to Lebanon

TENSIONS SURGE. Kuwait mistakenly shoots down US jets; Trump repeats calls for Iranians to overthrow their leaders

Reuters
Dubai

The US-Israeli airwar against Iran expanded on Monday with no end in sight as Israel attacked Lebanon in response to strikes by Hezbollah, while Tehran fired missiles and drones at Israel, Gulf states and a British air base in far-away Cyprus.

The US military said Kuwait's air defences had mistakenly shot down three American F-15E fighter jets during an Iranian attack. All six crew members ejected and were safely recovered.

The video, filmed at a location verified by Reuters, showed one of the planes spiralling out of the sky with an engine going up in flames.

NEW WAVE OF STRIKES
Iran's Revolutionary Guard Corps announced a new wave of strikes against Israel later on Monday.

After a weekend of bombing that killed Iran's supreme leader dragged its neighbours into war and shut

shipping traffic in the Gulf, markets opened on Monday with energy prices rising sharply, putting global economic recovery at risk.

In the biggest US foreign policy gamble in decades, President Donald Trump launched the campaign alongside Israel against a foe that had tormented the US and its allies for generations.

Trump repeated his calls for Iranians to rise up and overthrow their leaders, and said the air campaign could last weeks. Within Iran, where residents have jammed highways to flee cities as bombs fell, there was uncertainty about the future and emotion ranging from apprehension to euphoria.

Many Iranians openly celebrated the death of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, 86, who had ruled the country for 37 years and directed security forces that killed thousands of anti-government protesters at the start of this year.

But the conservative clerical leaders have shown no sign of yielding power.



DARK DAYS. Smoke rises following Israeli airstrikes on Dahiyeh, a southern suburb of Beirut, Lebanon, on Monday AP/PTI

Military experts say US and Israeli air power, with no armed forces on the ground, may not be enough to drive them out.

Meanwhile, scores of Iranians have been reported killed in strikes, including

several that hit apparent civilian targets.

"They are killing children, they are attacking hospitals. Is this the kind of democracy Trump wants to bring us? Innocent people were first killed by the regime and now

by Israel and the US," said Morteza Sedighi, a 52-year-old teacher from Tabriz. In a sign Iran's rulers are still reaching out to the outside world, a senior Iranian security official contacted Reuters to say Iran was

Rupee declines 50 paise to dollar as conflict intensifies

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The joint attacks on Iran had a ripple impact on the rupee, which weakened below 91 to the dollar and touched a one-month low on Monday.

The rupee was weighed down by FPI selling in the equity markets amid risk-off sentiment setting in, prompting investors to invest in safe-haven assets such as US Treasuries and gold, and hardening global crude oil and gold prices.

Opening weaker at 91.25 per dollar (down 28 paise compared with the previous close of 90.97), the rupee tested intraday high/low of 91.2150/91.4900. It closed at 91.47 per dollar, down 50 paise versus the previous close. The RBI is believed to have intervened in the forex market to prevent further

slide in the rupee.

Amit Pabari, MD, CR Forex Advisors, said: "It was a high-tension day for the rupee. The currency opened weak as markets digested weekend geopolitical developments and closed at 91.47, marking a 0.25 per cent decline – the sharpest single day fall since early February."

"The pressure came from multiple fronts — oil prices surged nearly 7 per cent, equity markets saw net selling of ₹7,314 crore with Sensex down 1,048 points and Nifty off 312 points, while the DXY touched 98.50, strengthening the dollar globally. Despite this, the rupee managed to hold below 91.50, suggesting some stabilising presence in the market," he said.

Pabari observed that it appears the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) had intervened selectively. According to the



ONE-MONTH LOW. The Indian unit was weighed down by FPI selling in the equity markets, amid risk-off sentiment setting in

latest RBI data, India's forex reserves stood at \$723.60 billion as of February 20, providing nearly 11 months of import cover and giving the RBI firepower to manage volatility.

The RBI seems to be allowing the rupee to adjust in

line with its Asian peers while preventing a disorderly move toward 92.00. Its focus remains on smoothing volatility, rather than defending a fixed level. In the near term, the rupee's direction will remain closely linked to global market sentiment, particularly geopolitical developments and capital flows.

"While the RBI is likely to monitor sharp currency movements and intervene when necessary, currency stability will also depend on how long these global uncertainties persist," he said.

SHARP PRESSURE
Abhishek Goenka, Founder & CEO, IFA Global, noted that the rupee came under sharp pressure, breaching the ₹91 per dollar mark and touching a one-month low, as escalating West Asian tensions triggered a broad risk-off move globally.

"Concerns around potential disruption in the Strait of Hormuz pushed crude oil prices sharply higher, strengthening the dollar and weighing on oil import-dependent currencies like the rupee. The currency

weakened about 0.5 per cent intraday before stabilising in the ₹91.4–₹91.5 range."

"The move was primarily driven by the surge in crude prices and safe-haven dollar demand, both of which materially worsen India's near-term external balance and inflation outlook," he said.

Goenka underscored that the pressure was visible across Asian currencies, with market participants cutting risk exposure and increasing hedges amid geopolitical uncertainty.

Positioning remained defensive, compounded by caution ahead of local market closures and elevated volatility in global markets.

He said the RBI appears to have intervened through state-run banks and forward markets to curb volatility, rather than defend a specific level which helped prevent a sharper slide.

Migrant workers in Gulf at risk as Iran retaliates

Bloomberg

Millions of migrant workers, who support some of the West Asia's most crucial sectors, are in the line of fire as Iran retaliates against the US-Israeli strikes that killed the Islamic Republic's supreme leader.

Southeast and South Asian nations supply a large share of the labour in the Gulf, including medical practitioners, construction workers and household help that make up a workforce the International Labour Organization (ILO) estimates at over 24 million.

The Philippines, Indonesia and Thailand said on Monday they are monitoring the location of their citizens and urged them to shelter in place. Evacuation and repatriation plans are also being prepared should the attacks worsen, they said in separate statements.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in an X post that he spoke to leader of UAE President Mohamed bin Zayed about "taking care" of the Indian community. The cabinet also directed all departments to "take necessary and feasible measures to assist Indian nationals affected by the development".

A Filipino caregiver was killed when she was struck by shrapnel while helping her ward reach a bomb shelter in Tel Aviv, Philippine President Ferdinand Marcos Jr said. Another Filipino worker was injured in Kuwait. The UAE reported three people killed from Pakistan, Nepal and Bangladesh. Migrant workers are crucial to the West Asia economy, accounting for over 40 per cent of the region's labour force, according to the ILO.

Export cargo stranded amid flight disruptions

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

With West Asian-based airlines suspending services to India for the past two days amid the Iran-Israel conflict, thousands of tonnes of export cargo, such as perishables, pharma and textiles bound for the US, Europe and Africa, are lying uncleared at airports across the country.

While the exact volume is unavailable, industry sources said about 450 tonnes of export cargo meant for West Asia/Gulf carriers are currently held up at Chennai airport alone. Terminal operators have also begun levying demurrage on the stranded shipments, a cost exporters will have to bear unless relief is granted.

J Krishnan, Partner, S Natesa Iyer Logistics LLP, a

Chennai-based freight forwarder, said cargo that had already been cleared by Customs on Friday and Saturday is yet to be uplifted, while a large volume reached airports on Sunday for clearance.

"The free period for exports is just 12 hours," he said, adding that alternative routing options and frequencies are sparse, leading to cancellations and claims for delayed despatches.

With no immediate alternatives emerging, Krishnan said the financial burden needs to be mitigated through emergency measures by the Centre.

EMERGENCY MEASURES
Trade bodies have written to the Ministry of Civil Aviation seeking a waiver of demurrage charges during this unprecedented disruption that's beyond the control of



exporters. A Sakthivel, Chairman of the Apparel Export Promotion Council, said the prevailing situation has directly impacted the timely movement of export cargo.

"Imposing demurrage under such exceptional circumstances will place an undue financial burden on exporters already facing shipment delays and contractual un-

certainties," he said. Sakthivel urged the DGCA to issue instructions to cargo terminal operators to waive demurrage on export consignments affected by flight disruptions and airspace restrictions arising from the ongoing Middle East crisis.

MINISTRY'S RESPONSE
Samir J Shah, President of the Air Cargo Agents Association of India, also said levying demurrage in such cases will be unjustified and exacerbate commercial uncertainties, he said. The industry is now awaiting a response from the Ministry of Civil Aviation.

Jitendra Srivastava, CEO, Triton Logistics & Maritime, said a significant portion of India's outbound air freight moves through hubs such as Dubai, Doha and Abu Dhabi for onward connections to the US, Europe and Africa.

Carriers impose surcharge up to \$4,000/container

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Exporting cargo to the Arabian Peninsula by sea is set to get costlier as global container lines levy war-related surcharge amid the grim security situation triggered by the West Asian conflict.

Shipping lines are imposing emergency conflict surcharge (ECS) and war risk surcharge (WRS) ranging between \$1,500 and \$4,000 per container for cargo moving to and from various ports in the Arabian Peninsula. Some carriers have also stopped accepting cargo for the region.

French shipping firm CMA CGM said it will levy an

ECS from Monday. The ECS will be \$2,000 per 20-foot dry container, \$3,000 per 40-foot dry container and \$4,000 per reefer or special equipment.

NECESSARY STEPS
The levy applies to all cargo moving to or from Iraq, Bahrain, Kuwait, Yemen, Qatar, Oman, the United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, Jordan, Egypt (Port of Ain Sokhna), Djibouti, Sudan and Eritrea.

"We understand these measures may impact your logistics and supply chain operations; however, they are necessary steps that also lead to additional operational costs," the company said.

German carrier Hapag-



ON EXPECTED LINES. Industry sources said the imposition of war-related levies was expected, given the need for carriers to recover higher operational and insurance costs REUTERS

Lloyd has introduced a WRS for cargo to and from the Upper Gulf, Arabian Gulf and Persian Gulf, citing the volatile situation around the

Strait of Hormuz and the resulting operational disruptions that are impacting schedules and equipment availability.

The WRS, effective Monday, will be \$1,500 per 20-foot equivalent unit (TEU) for standard containers and \$3,500 per container for reefer boxes and special equipment.

SUSPENDS BOOKING
Meanwhile, Swiss major MSC Mediterranean Shipping Company, as a precautionary measure, has suspended all bookings to the West Asian region until further notice.

Industry sources said the imposition of war-related levies was expected, given the need for carriers to recover higher operational and insurance costs, but added that the quantum of the surcharges was steep.

defending itself against aggressors and will continue to do so.

A major new front in the war opened on Monday when Hezbollah, one of Tehran's principal allies in West Asia, launched missiles and drones toward Israel in retaliation for the killing of Khamenei.

ALLIES UNDER ATTACK
Washington's allies came under renewed attack from Iranian missiles and drones. Black smoke rose above the area around the US embassy in Kuwait, where there was a heavy presence of security, ambulances and fire trucks. There were loud blasts in Dubai and Samha in the UAE, and in Doha, capital of Qatar.

RAS TANURA SHUT
Meanwhile, Saudi Arabia shut its biggest domestic oil refinery on Monday after a drone strike.

Attacks on the region stretched into a third day, resulting in the suspension of most oil production in Iraqi Kurdistan and several

major Israeli gas fields, throttling exports to Egypt.

State oil giant Saudi Aramco's 5,50,000 barrels per day (bpd) Ras Tanura refinery, which was shut as a precautionary measure, is part of an energy complex on the kingdom's Gulf coast, which also serves as a critical export terminal for Saudi crude oil.

In Iraqi Kurdistan, which exported 2,00,000 barrels of oil per day (bpd) via pipeline to Turkey's Ceyhan port in February, companies, including DNO, Gulf Keystone Petroleum, Dana Gas and HKN Energy, stopped output at their fields as a precaution, with no damage reported.

Offshore Israel, the Israeli government instructed Chevron to temporarily shut down the giant Leviathan gas field where it is in the process of expanding capacity to around 21 billion cubic metres a year as part of a \$35 billion export deal to Egypt.

A spokesperson for Chevron, which also operates the Tamar gas field offshore Israel, said its facilities were safe.

GIC Re ceases marine hull war cover for high-risk zones

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

No insurance companies will get marine hull war risk reinsurance support from GIC Re for certain high-risk zones with effect from Tuesday evening for an indefinite period.

This move from GIC Re, the largest reinsurer in the domestic reinsurance market in India, came after the US-Israeli military operation against Iran and the country retaliating by attacking several West Asian countries.

In a notice on March 1, the reinsurance company said it will cease to cover the marine hull war risks for certain high-risk zones from 1900 hours IST on March 3.

These areas include parts of the Persian or Arabian Gulf, Gulf of Oman, Iran and all other countries under sanction, certain areas of Black Sea and Sea of Azov, waters linked to Russia, Ukraine and Belarus, as well as select stretches of Red Sea, Gulf of Aden and Indian Ocean.

48-HOUR NOTICE
GIC Re's decision will impact both public and private sector general insurance companies in the marine hull space.

"GIC had sent the 48-hour

notice to the insurers on March 1, informing about the withdrawal of the overage. Accordingly, we have sent notices to all our clients (shipping lines) that they will no longer have the marine hull cover with effect from 7 pm on Tuesday," a top official of a general insurance company told *businessline*.

"Till the embargo is there, a shipping company may seek cover under the marine hull by paying extra premium if the company still needs to operate in these high-risk zones. This is optional," the official said.

In the coming days, a meeting of reinsurers is scheduled to be held where all reinsurance companies are likely to decide their action plans on marine hull insurance.

"Amid the heightened geopolitical risk in the West Asia, major shipping lines have already been affected. It will likely result in war risk cover being completely withdrawn. The war cover for new risks would be either unavailable and even if available would be extremely expensive. This can mean that the cost of shipping will go up considerably," said Hari Radhakrishnan, Expert, Insurance Brokers Association of India (IBAI).

(With inputs from G Naga Sridhar in Hyderabad)

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NOTICE
[For transfer of equity shares of the Company to Investor Education and Protection Fund (IEPF)]
The notice is published pursuant to provisions of the Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority (Accounting, Audit Transfer & Refund) Rules, 2016 ('the Rules') as amended from time to time. The Rules, inter alia, contain provisions for transfer of shares in respect of which dividend has not been claimed by the shareholder for seven consecutive years or more to IEPF Authority. Shareholders are requested to note that in respect of interim dividend declared in March 15, 2019 if the dividend is not claimed on or before April 15, 2026, those equity shares in respect of which dividend remains unclaimed, including all benefits accruing on such shares, shall be transferred to IEPF Authority as per timelines and procedure prescribed in the Rules, without giving any further notice to the shareholder and no liability shall lie against the company in respect of which equity shares so transferred. The Company has communicated to the concerned shareholders individually whose shares are liable to be transferred to the IEPF Authority under the said Rules for taking appropriate action in compliance with the said Rules. The Company has also updated the details of such shareholders and shares due for transfer to the IEPF Authority on its website at unitednilgiritea.com. Shareholders are requested to verify the details of unclaimed dividends and the shares liable to be transferred to the IEPF Authority on the Company's web-site under 'Corporate' at unitednilgiritea.com. Shareholders may note that both the unclaimed dividend and corresponding shares transferred to the IEPF Authority including all benefits accruing on such shares, if any, can be claimed back from the IEPF Authority after following the procedure prescribed in the Rules. In case the shareholders have any queries or need any further information / clarification on the subject matter of the Rules, they may contact the Company Secretary, The United Nilgiri Tea Estates Company Limited., No 3, Savithri Shannmugam Road, Race Course, Coimbatore - 641 018 (or) the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent M/s. Integrated Registry Management Services Private Limited, 'Kences Towers' No 1, Ramakrishna Street, North Usman Road, T. Nagar, Chennai - 600 017 e-mail: corpserve@integratedindia.com phone(044) 28140801. Please ensure to provide following details in all your communications: (1) Name of the Company (2) Folio No or DP Id and Client Id (3) Name of shareholder (4) (3) Name of shareholder (4) valid e-mail Id. Also please provide self-attested KYC document of the shareholder like PAN, cancelled cheque leaf and latest utility bill as address proof.

For The United Nilgiri Tea Estates Company Limited
Place: Coimbatore
Date : 02.03.2026
R.V. SRIDHARAN
Company Secretary

Strong base

New GDP series affirms growth robustness

The new GDP series released for this year and the preceding two fiscals — with the base year shifted from 2011-12 to 2022-23 — provides some reason for cheer in these war-torn, deeply anxious times. The second advance estimate under the new series pegs real growth rate at 7.6 per cent this fiscal, against 7.4 per cent in the first advance estimate under the old series. The new dataset not just confirms the essential soundness of the economy, but also reaffirms faith in the reliability of our statistics.



The Centre has responded well to criticism on the accuracy of India's growth numbers (from the IMF in particular), by making methodological changes, incorporating high frequency data, such as GST collections, and weaving in survey findings with respect to employment and consumption. A real growth rate of 7.6 per cent for FY26 implies the same growth rate in Q4 as well. However, Q4 growth might dip on account of global headwinds; some analysts put it at 7.3 per cent. Likewise, the Centre's expectation of 7.4 per cent growth in FY27 might need to be calibrated, if the war carries on. A feature of this fiscal year's growth story has been the 11.5 per cent growth in manufacturing GVA, against 9.3 per cent in FY25 and 12.3 per cent in FY24. Agriculture has not fared too well, with GVA growth coming in at 2.4 per cent, against 4.2 per cent last year. Services GVA growth at 9 per cent marks an impressive rise over 7 per cent and 7.9 per cent, respectively, in FY24 and FY25. This could take a bit of a knock on global turbulence.

That said, the new GDP series does generate some food for thought. Real growth rates are up over the old series, but the actual size of the economy, or the nominal GDP, is down in each of these years. Nominal growth rates are not significantly different, but the new series' estimates are less volatile. But the smaller size of the economy itself seems curious, given that the inclusion of new data, such as GST collections to bolster the corporate data base, the unorganised enterprises survey as well as diverse data sources for agriculture, should have had a contrary effect. Nominal GDP is down by about 3.5 per cent in each of the three years in question. Private consumption is down by even more, while government expenditure and net exports are up. It is noteworthy that agriculture estimates have been bolstered by the inclusion of new data on fisheries, fodder and milk products. Yet, if the nominal GDP is lower, it perhaps suggests that the earlier process of extrapolation was not free of problems.

Besides including more datasets, the introduction of double deflators for output and input, respectively, to derive real GDP is a welcome improvement. It would reduce the distortions of using a single deflator with a WPI bias. Our GDP estimates, both real and nominal, should serve as accurate indicators for policymaking. India's statistical system has been regarded as among the best. The latest changes will bolster this reputation.

OTHER VOICES.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

EUROPE

It's too soon for Iran 'off-ramps'

The first two days of the US-Israeli attack on Iran have been a striking success, but the response of the Iranian regime has also revealed the reason it was necessary. The biggest mistake President Trump could make now would be to end the war too soon, before Iran's military and its domestic terror forces have been more thoroughly destroyed. The precise targeting of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and some 40 regime leaders is a remarkable demonstration of US and Israeli intelligence capability. It underscores how much last June's attack had degraded Iran's capacity to compete in the skies or mount a major retaliatory response. Three Americans were killed and five wounded on the weekend, but the risk of casualties would be greater had the President waited to let Iran rearm. (NEW YORK, MARCH 1)

GULF NEWS

The Gulf at the heart of global shifts

The regional as well as the global scene is no longer merely drifting towards conflict; it is accelerating into a new and dangerous phase of open confrontation. The military strikes launched by the United States and Israel against Iran on 28 February 2026 marked a watershed moment in an already fragile regional regime and international order. What had previously been a shadow confrontation — managed through deterrence, proxies, and calibrated escalation — has now shifted into direct and overt military engagement, with profound implications not only for the Middle East but also for the global system at large. This escalation unfolded at a time when the international environment was already strained by economic fragility. (DUBAI, MARCH 2)

Easing key bottlenecks in cities

WAY FORWARD. Delegating financial and planning power to locally elected officials can improve urban governance



ASHIMA GOYAL

Many Indians say it does not feel their country is growing at 7-8 per cent. Growth creates its own tensions, with both concentrated in cities, which lag in facilities, in air quality, in resources and in governance. Overcrowding, congestion, constant construction, pollution — all reduce the quality of life. Animals freely roam the streets threatening themselves, local populations and livelihoods. Shelters and neutering, even if mandated, are not implemented.

The Centre and major regulators have embarked on a drive to simplify regulations. But business does not find life getting any easier since the local officials it has to deal with are largely untouched by change.

The key bottleneck is governance more than resources. It has its genesis in the over-centralisation and control mechanisms inherited from the British. Independence added planning or developmental institutions to the Constitutional, Central and State agencies to be found in every city. There is no clear coordination or hierarchy across multiple agencies. It is the State, not city governments, that control vital functions such as water supply and some types of transport.

Politicians respond to numbers and the majority of population was rural. As the belief that India lives in its villages became ingrained, the bulk of resources were directed to rural areas. The fear of losing these has prevented budding urban clusters from declaring themselves as cities and providing the required services. But the belief lags reality. The last census was only in 2011 and measured 31 per cent of India's population as living in cities. Private estimates that include satellite data and night-light imaging, suggest it may be above 70 per cent, if peri-urban areas are added. Even so, there is no policy framework to ease the ongoing transition from rural to urban. The absence of adequate data compounds the problem.

Even so, large amounts have been spent on city infrastructure, but results remain inadequate in the absence of coordination and attention to user needs. For example, if congestion is



GAP. Indian cities' own source revenue is only 20-40 per cent of municipal expenditure

alleviated on one stretch, it springs up in another in the absence of planned city-wide expansion. Even if public transport improves, its use is not enough to ease congestion since last mile connections are not thought through. While low income housing is being created, large slum areas are demolished together, displacing people from their places of work rather than staggering so that some rebuilding is completed and rehousing in the same area is possible.

The smart city initiative has designed many digital systems to improve public services, but operational silos continue. One department does not share data with another, let alone train own use-based AI on the data.

RESPECTING THE CONSTITUTION
In 1992 the 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments did lay the framework for decentralisation, recommending the transfer of funds and **Large amounts have been spent on city infrastructure, but results remain inadequate in the absence of coordination and attention to user needs**

functionaries to local governments based on awards of State Finance Commissions. But most States either do not set up the commissions regularly or do not listen to them. It is difficult to give up funds and power and there are always excuses such as local corruption or lack of capacity. But the latter cannot survive for decades, as they have done, if strong local systems are in place for accountability and there is sincere training.

There are signs, at last, that the critical bottleneck is being recognised and acted on. Both NITI Aayog and the Economic Survey have flagged the necessity of a master plan for cities. The latter gives the example of Noida in UP where a single authority has delivered much better outcomes than Gurugram, Haryana, where there are three overlapping authorities. But how is this to be achieved?

In the OUP Handbook I had edited 10 years ago I had suggested that constitutional institutions should have priority and coordination authority. Today technology can enable coordination, once a clear hierarchy is established. In East Asian countries decentralisation is incentivised since local authorities, as residual claimants, benefit from prosperity. In most global cities an empowered mayor is elected and responsible for outcomes. In Indian

What the smoke signals from Dubai portend

Wars begin when multiple strategic clocks — political, nuclear, regional, and monetary — strike at once

Chocko Valliappa

For the past 24 hours, I have been confined indoors in Dubai, watching smoke hang near the horizon from the 63rd floor of an apartment overlooking the Burj Khalifa. The sounds in the distance are not cinematic. They are unsettling. When geopolitics moves from headlines to skyline, theory becomes personal.

In four decades of working with global CEOs through YPO (Young Presidents' Organization), EO (Entrepreneurs' Organization) and in building businesses across seven countries, I have learned one thing: wars rarely begin because of one event. They begin when multiple strategic clocks strike at once.

The first clock is political: In the US, elections shape foreign policy narratives. Iran has been an unresolved strategic chapter since 1979. Any administration that can project strength towards Tehran gains domestic credibility. As electoral cycles tighten, leadership signalling becomes sharper.

In Israel, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has operated under sustained political pressure. The October 7 attacks transformed national security from policy debate to existential urgency. In such moments, political consolidation around force is not unusual. Leaders under strain rarely choose passivity. But politics alone does not start wars.

The second clock is nuclear: Israel's doctrine has always been clear: prevent

adversaries from crossing irreversible nuclear thresholds. The concern is not incremental enrichment but the narrowing window towards weaponisation capability. If decision-makers believe that window is closing, diplomacy begins to look slow and uncertain. Pre-emption begins to look decisive. Timing clock of diplomacy slows time, technology accelerates it. When those trajectories diverge, escalation becomes more probable — even if talks in Geneva or Vienna are technically ongoing. In fact, military action during negotiations is often about leverage, not abandonment.

REGIONAL INSTABILITY
The clock of regional instability: Iran sits in a volatile arc: Pakistan-Afghanist tensions, unrest in Balochistan, proxy alignments across West Asia, and increasing Chinese and Russian strategic presence. In my years of expanding operations across jurisdictions — from Asia to the Middle East to North America — I have learned that risk is rarely linear. Instability in one node amplifies vulnerability in another.

Energy and currency clock — quieter, structural, and perhaps the least discussed. Since the mid-1970s, global oil trade has largely been denominated in US dollars — the so-called petrodollar system. This architecture has underpinned American monetary primacy for decades. Oil-exporting nations earned dollars and recycled them into US assets, reinforcing global



UNCERTAINTY. More unnerving than hostility REUTERS

dollar demand. In recent years, that architecture has shown stress. India and China have expanded purchases of Russian oil through alternative settlement arrangements. Iran has traded outside traditional dollar channels. BRICS discussions have increasingly referenced reducing dollar dependency in cross-border trade. Energy is not just a commodity. It anchors financial power.

If meaningful oil flows migrate away from dollar settlement, the implications extend to foreign exchange reserves, sovereign debt markets, and long-term monetary influence. No major power treats such shifts casually.

Viewed through this lens, economic tools — sanctions, tariff pressures linked indirectly to energy trade patterns, strategic engagement with producers such as Venezuela — take on a broader meaning. They are not merely punitive; they are structural.

This does not mean the current

cities the elected mayor tends to be a ceremonial head while the Municipal Commissioner, an IAS officer appointed by the State Government, is the real executive. Financial and planning power is not delegated to the locally elected official, who is more likely to be responsive to voter needs.

USING FINANCE

While governance, not finance, is the real constraint, financial powers with constitutional bodies can be used to improve delegation to local authorities. Executive power follows financial powers.

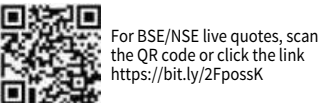
The latest Budget does focus on city economic regions, with an allocation of ₹5,000 crore per region over five years based on reform-cum-growth results. Coordination worsens as peri-urban areas expand with their own authority structures. A single elected authority, with incentives aligned to development, could be imposed as a pre-condition for the region.

The 16th Finance Commission (FC) has a number of initiatives for urban areas. While tax devolution is a State right and has to be formula-based, conditionalities can be imposed on grants. The FC has made liberal use of this freedom. The overall allocation to urban local bodies has doubled and the untied component gone up to 50 per cent giving them more freedom to respond to local needs, but the rest is tied to sanitation systems and audit requirements, including for parastatals, to improve capacity, transparency and accountability. An urbanisation premium of ₹10,000 crore will reduce the incentive to remain rural and deny urban services.

Indian cities' Own Source Revenue (OSR) varies between 20 and 40 per cent of municipal expenditure. Property tax at 0.15 per cent of GDP is much below the 0.3 for low-income and up to 3 per cent for high-income countries. The FC has linked performance grants to OSR growth, and State transfers of at least 20 per cent of the FC basic grant to local governments, thus delinking devolution from underperforming State FCs. Own revenues create natural residual claimants with decision powers.

There is a beginning in relaxing the vital choke points and aligning incentives to improve urban governance and delivery. These changes may also help reverse the underperformance in actual Central spending on urban development over the last three years.

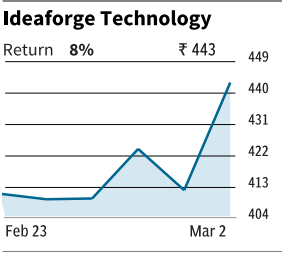
The writer was a member of the previous MPC



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QUICKLY.

Defence stocks soar;
Ideaforge Tech jumps 8%



New Delhi: Defence stocks such as Ideaforge Technology and Paras Defence closed higher on Monday amid escalating tensions in West Asia in the wake of an attack on Iran by the US and Israel. Shares of Ideaforge Technology jumped 7.66 per cent, Paras Defence and Space Technologies surged 5.95 per cent, Bharat Electronics climbed 2.09 per cent, Astra Microwave Products advanced 1.62 per cent, Taneja Aerospace & Aviation shot up 1.34 per cent, Hindustan Aeronautics went up 0.96 per cent and Bharat Dynamics was up 0.22 per cent on the BSE. ■■

SEBI slaps ₹38 lakh penalty on Coffee Day, officials

New Delhi: SEBI has imposed penalties totalling ₹38 lakh on Coffee Day Enterprises and several of its officials for failing to comply with mandatory accounting and disclosure requirements while preparing financial statements. SEBI observed that the company did not adhere to Indian Accounting Standards in the preparation of its standalone and consolidated financial statements, as well as quarterly financial results. It also noted that the company failed to disclose the reasons for deviations from prescribed accounting standards, as mandated under the Companies Act, 2013. ■■

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Target: ₹940
CMP: ₹782.90
In-line with India's finished stainless steel (SS) production growth trajectory, the volume of Jindal Stainless (JDSL) is likely to rise 9 per cent year on year in FY26e, moderate to about 6 per cent in FY27e and rebound to >10 per cent in FY28e, depicting a 'V-shaped' growth trajectory over FY26-28e. Commissioning of downstream facilities at Jajpur in H2-FY27 is likely to temporarily mute volume in FY27, due to transition and ramp-up timelines. However, once the downstream VAP units stabilise, aided by incremental volume from Indonesia, we expect volume to rise to about 3 million tonne in FY28e. Recent 8 per cent uptick in domestic SS prices and price hike by marquee global and domestic players augur well for realisation and profitability in Q4FY26e. Further, as the downstream facility ramps up to rated capacity, JDSL's profitability is likely to improve structurally, aiding margin expansion. We expect EBITDA to clock about 12.7 per cent CAGR over FY26-28e. Robust domestic demand and strong volume trajectory in FY28 are likely to aid profitability. Given the sector's re-rating over the past few years and improving earnings visibility, we maintain BUY rating on the stock with an upwardly revised TP of ₹940 (from ₹900 earlier), valuing it at 10.5x FY28e EV/EBITDA (median of its five-year one-year rolling average plus +1SD).
Key risks: Further extension of QCO; extension in capex-timeline; slower ramp-up of downstream (CRAP) unit; and volatility in key RM prices

Axis Securities

FORTIS HEALTHCARE (BUY)
Target: ₹1,038
CMP: ₹932.85
Fortis has delivered a strong performance in 9M-FY26, supported by structural growth momentum in the healthcare industry. Consolidated revenue and EBITDA margins stood at ₹6,763 crore and 22.9 per cent, respectively, registering a robust 17.1 per cent growth, primarily driven by the hospital segment, which reported 19.1 per cent growth. average occupancy at 69 per cent and ARPOB at ₹70,500. Following the rebranding of its diagnostics business from SRL to Agilus Diagnostics, the division reported revenue growth of 7.7 per cent to ₹1,139 crore. Operating EBITDA increased to ₹275 crore from ₹185 crore, resulting in margin expansion to 24.1 per cent (vs 17.5 per cent). Fortis continues to execute its cluster-based growth strategy, adding about 750 operational beds YTD through acquisitions and leases. The ₹430-crore acquisition of People Tree Hospitals provides an immediate 125-bed presence in a key Bengaluru micro-market. The launch of specialised facilities such as Adayu (mental health) enhances clinical depth and strengthens Fortis' positioning in high-demand urban clusters. The company has announced 3,200+ beds over the next three years. Fortis is currently trading at 27x/23x EV/EBITDA for FY27E/FY28E. We recommend a Buy with a TP of ₹1,038, implying an upside of about 10 per cent from the CMP.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

Sensex, Nifty slump 1% as marketmen turn cautious on fears of Iran conflict impact

DEEPER PAIN. Small- and mid-cap indices see steeper fall; Nifty Next50 plunges 1.52%, capturing broader mood

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

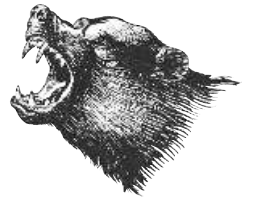
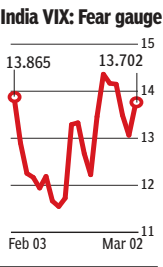
Equities closed sharply lower on Monday after a steep gap-down start triggered by escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia, with benchmark indices posting their biggest single-day fall in weeks before recovering partially in late trade. The BSE Sensex settled at 80,238.85, down 1,048.34 points from its previous close of 81,287.19 after opening at 78,543.73. The NSE Nifty 50 ended at 24,865.70, declining 312.95 points after touching an intra-day low near 24,600. **HEAVY SELL-OFF** Market breadth remained decisively negative, with 3,641 stocks declining against 754

advances on the BSE, while 869 stocks hit 52-week lows. Selling pressure was broad-based across sectors, with Nifty Midcap 100 falling 1.58 per cent, Nifty Smallcap 100 dropping 1.75 per cent, Nifty Bank declining 1.14 per cent to 59,839.65 and Nifty Financial Services slipping 1.10 per cent. Nifty Next 50 fell 1.52 per cent. Among Nifty gainers, Bharat Electronics rose 2.13 per cent, Hindalco Industries gained 1.70 per cent, Sun Pharmaceutical Industries advanced 0.93 per cent, ONGC added 0.63 per cent and ITC edged up 0.35 per cent. On the losing side, Inter-Globe Aviation fell 6.09 per cent, L&T declined 5.24 per cent, Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone dropped 3.43 per cent, Maruti Suzuki India

Under bear attack

Index	Close	Chg (pts)	Chg (%)
BSE Sensex	80,238.85	-1,048.34	-1.29
Nifty50	24,865.70	-312.95	-1.24
Nifty Next50	68,650.25	-1,060.65	-1.52
BSE 500	35,812.02	-510.54	-1.41
BSE 1000	10,605.34	-155.30	-1.44
BSE India 150	18,715.15	-251.18	-1.32
BSE MidCap	44,898.55	-731.92	-1.60
BSE SmallCap	47,520.99	-983.66	-2.03

Nifty draggers	Close (₹)	% fall
IndiGo	4,520.40	-6.36
L&T	4,066.70	-4.95
Adani Ports	1,470.30	-3.33
Maruti Suzuki	14,388.00	-3.16
Asian Paints	2,307.10	-2.91



slipped 3.29 per cent. Volatility spiked sharply during the session, with India VIX rising more than 20 per cent, reflecting heightened risk aversion. Analysts linked the sell-off

to geopolitical escalation and surging crude prices. Vinod Nair, Geojit Investments said, "Rising geopolitical tensions in West Asia have unsettled global markets... Rising crude oil prices and a

Gold, Silver ETFs sizzle

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The bearish and volatile trend in the equity markets has pushed seasoned investors to place their bets on exchange-traded funds with underlying precious metals, which are riding high on geopolitical tensions across the globe. Gold ETFs jumped 5-8 per cent, as the demand for the yellow metal on stock exchanges increased amid a meltdown in key equity indices and individual stocks. Silver ETFs were up 8-9 per cent. Gold AUM increased to ₹1.84 lakh crore in January against ₹51,839 crore

logged in the same period last year. Similarly, silver AUM increased to ₹1.17 lakh crore (₹13,566 crore). Inflows into gold ETFs have touched ₹96,195 crore last year and it remained strong in January at ₹24,040 crore as investors used the fall in gold prices to invest more in the yellow metal. **SILVER SURGE** The net inflow in silver ETFs more than doubled in January to ₹9,463 crore compared to an inflow of ₹3,962 crore in December 2025. The silver ETF AUM had surged 61 per cent to hit a new high of ₹1.16 lakh crore in January 2026 against ₹72,652 crore in December

2025 on the back of a sharp jump in prices. Akshat Garg, Head-Research & Product, Choice Wealth, said when the Nifty slipped down 1.2 per cent to 24,865 points and uncertainty gripped markets again, investor confidence wobbled. Gold ETF marked the ninth straight month of net inflows in January, and silver drawing attention partly as a defensive play with growing industrial demand from electric vehicles and solar manufacturing, he said. Investors today are more aware of risk concentration and they are more open to holding a mix of growth assets and defensive buffers, he added.

Shree Ram Twistex makes weak debut, tumbles over 31%

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Shares of cotton yarn manufacturer Shree Ram Twistex on Monday ended with a discount of over 31 per cent against the issue price of ₹104. The stock began trading at ₹70, a decline of 32.69 per cent from the issue price on the BSE. Later, it ended at ₹73.45, down 29.38 per cent. At the NSE, the stock started trading at ₹68, a drop of 34.61 per cent. Shares of the firm ended at ₹71.40, a discount of 31.34 per cent.

Chartered accountants' body seeks change in SGB tax, dividend rules

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

A chartered accountants' body has raised concerns over several tax proposals in the Finance Bill, including changes affecting Sovereign Gold Bonds (SGBs), dividend taxation and withholding rules, saying that some provisions could disrupt investors and businesses if implemented without tweaks. In its post-Budget representation to the Finance Ministry, the Bombay Chartered Accountants' Society (BCAS) said, "Withdrawal of capital gains exemption on such bonds purchased in the sec-

ondary market adversely impacts those investors who already invested in them on the promise of getting tax-free redemptions." **INVESTOR PROTECTION** In its memorandum, the BCAS suggested that the change should apply only to bonds issued after February 1, 2026, to protect existing investors. It raised concerns over the proposal to disallow interest deductions against dividend income. The move could hit sectors such as infrastructure, real estate and financial services, where investments are often structured through holding

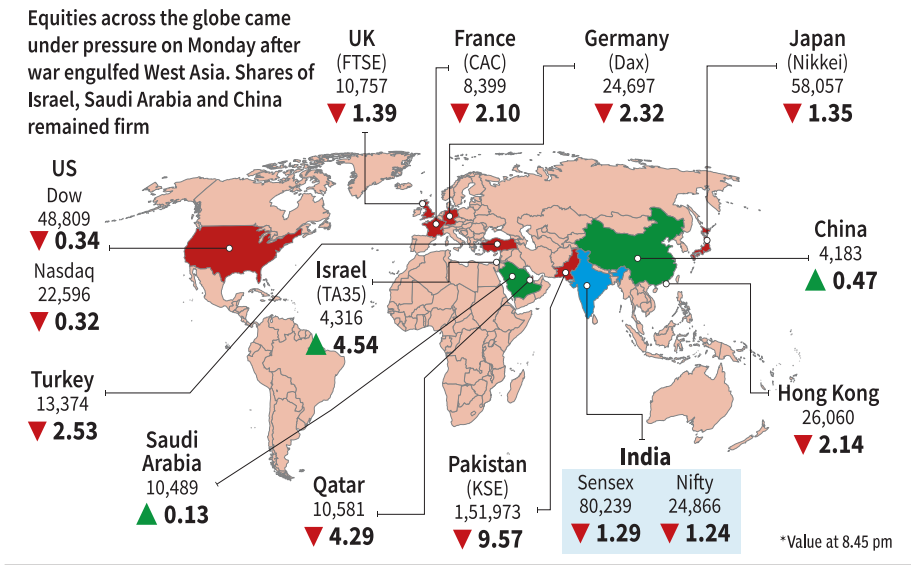
companies or SPVs, it said. "The amendment will lead to loss of interest payment in case of borrowed funds utilised for investment purposes," the representation said, adding that it could raise borrowing costs and make some projects commercially unviable. Among other recommendations, the BCAS called for rationalising tax deduction at source (TDS) rates between professional and technical services to reduce disputes and compliance burdens. It also urged the government to ease certain prosecution provisions for tax lapses and address drafting anomalies in immunity provisions.

Global stocks drop as traders weigh Iran war risks

Bloomberg/Reuters

Stocks dropped on Monday morning as traders weighed the market risks from an escalating conflict in West Asia, with oil spiking and President Donald Trump saying the US and Israeli strikes on Iran may last weeks. The S&P 500 opened 0.7 per cent lower on Monday, led by the consumer discretionary and communication services sectors. The move lower was broad-based with more than three stocks falling for every one that gained. AES Corp was the worst-performing stock in the index on Monday morning after BlackRock's GIP and EQT bought the company for \$10.7 billion, which Bloomberg Intelligence said was below market expectations. The tech-heavy Nasdaq 100 Index fell 0.7 per cent, while the blue-chip Dow Jones Industrial Average fell 0.8 per cent. "We expect this safe-

Israel shines, Pakistan plunges, others wobble



haven mode to be in full force this week," said David Bahnsen, Chief Investment Officer at Bahnsen Group. He noted energy had been the top-performing of 11 sectors in the S&P 500 Index before the US and Israeli

strikes on Iran and "we expect this sector to continue its run, thanks to supply fears, increasing demand and since the sector is still trading at much more attractive valuations than technology." The Cboe Volatility Index,

known as the fear gauge, climbed and "implied volatilities are up across asset classes following the US/Israeli strikes on Iran over the weekend," said Mandy Xu, Vice-President and Head of Derivatives Markets Intelli-

gence at Cboe Bats LLC. Bourses in Kuwait and the United Arab Emirates temporarily closed, citing "exceptional circumstances." The blue-chip FTSE 100 fell 1 per cent by 1131 GMT, having touched a record high in the prior session, while the domestically oriented FTSE 250 index tumbled 1.3 per cent.

ISRAEL AT NEW HIGH The Nikkei 225 closed 1.3 per cent down in Tokyo, while the broader Topix fell 1 per cent. Banks led the decline, along with exporters like electronics and drugmakers. Miners and shipping firms bucked the trend, climbing after Brent crude oil rose as much as 13.7 per cent. However, Tel Aviv shares rose sharply to all-time highs on Monday and the shekel gained against the dollar. The blue-chip Tel Aviv 35 index and broader TA-125 were both up around 4.5 per cent having been as much as 5 per cent higher earlier in the day.

Clean Max Enviro plunges 18% to ₹867.90 on Day 1 of listing

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Shares of Clean Max Enviro Energy Solutions made a weak debut on Monday, and settled nearly 18 per cent below the issue price of ₹1,053. The stock opened at ₹960 on the NSE, reflecting a discount of about 8.83 per cent, while on the BSE it debuted at ₹952.20, down 9.57 per cent from the upper end of the price-band. Selling pressure intensified post-listing as the stock ended at ₹867.90 and ₹867.50 on the BSE and NSE, respectively. Shivani Nyati, Head of Wealth at Swastika Investment, said the company's market debut was below expectations despite reasonable institutional participation. Advising investors, she said, "Investors should remain cautious in the short



MARKING ITS DEBUT. Ashish Chauhan (second from left), MD and CEO, NSE, with officials of Clean Max Enviro Energy Solutions at the listing ceremony on Monday

term. Allottees may hold if risk appetite is high, but should maintain a strict stop-loss at ₹900." "Fresh investors are advised to wait for price stability and strong demand support before considering new positions," she said. **₹3,100-CRORE IPO** The ₹3,100-crore initial public offering (IPO) of Clean Max Enviro Energy Solutions, a commercial and in-

dustrial renewable energy provider, was subscribed just 94 per cent. The qualified institutional buyers' portion was subscribed 2.83 times. However, the non-institutional investors' category saw 54 per cent subscription, while the retail individual investors' segment was subscribed just 6 per cent. Ahead of the IPO, the company raised ₹921 crore from anchor investors.

India INX GA to expand overseas investment access

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

The India International Exchange (India INX) on Monday announced a strategic partnership between its wholly-owned subsidiary, India INX Global Access IFSC (India INX GA), and HSBC International Financial Services Centre Banking Unit (HSBC IBU) to expand structured access to global investment products for Indian investors through Gift City. India INX GA, a Global Access Provider (GAP) registered with the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA), will leverage its global product offerings to broaden the range of international investment opportunities available to HSBC IBU clients. The arrangement is designed to enable informed cross-border participation and more efficient

capital allocation beyond domestic asset classes, stated an official release here. The development comes days after NSE IX launched its own global access platform last week, underscoring the growing momentum within the IFSC ecosystem to facilitate overseas portfolio diversification for Indian investors under a regulated framework. Vijay Krishnamurthy, MD and CEO, India INX, stated the referral arrangement represents another step in expanding India INX GA as a credible international investment gateway network. As investor appetite for global diversification continues to rise, structured access through trusted global institutions is becoming increasingly important, he said, adding that India INX remains committed to building a compliant and efficient ecosystem that connects Indian capital with global opportunities.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 312.95 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Bharat Elec	453.95	7.27	55.65	1.43	
Hindalco	940.00	4.86	13.14	1.20	
Sun Pharma	1752.50	3.60	38.39	1.64	
ITC	314.90	2.75	19.06	2.68	
ONGC	282.20	2.13	7.89	0.97	
Dr Reddys Lab	1294.40	1.08	19.56	0.70	
JSW Steel	1267.30	0.54	39.91	1.05	
Cipla	1351.60	0.42	24.08	0.67	
SBI Life	2032.20	-0.49	83.07	0.80	
Apollito Hosp	7791.50	-0.68	60.04	0.71	
Max Healthcare	1083.60	-1.36	74.27	0.71	
Wipro	198.57	-1.50	15.62	0.50	
Tech Mahindra	1345.40	-1.73	28.71	0.75	
PowerGrid Corp	296.80	-1.84	17.78	1.19	
Grasim Ind	2777.30	-1.89	19.96	0.94	
HDPC Life	707.30	-1.89	80.60	0.67	
Westelndia	1279.70	-1.89	75.66	0.81	
Adani Enter	2124.60	-2.13	17.35	0.49	
Coal India	426.25	-2.19	8.83	0.85	
TataConsumerProduct	1125.20	-2.26	75.67	0.65	
Tata Steel	211.01	-2.39	28.88	1.54	
Trent Ltd.	3848.50	-2.48	84.46	0.75	
Kotak Bank	413.10	-3.39	21.86	2.68	
Hind Unilever	2320.60	-3.41	54.23	1.82	
Bharti Airtel	1873.20	-3.73	28.83	4.60	
UltraTech Cement	15221.00	-4.06	48.15	1.31	
HCL Tech	1371.00	-4.19	22.59	1.28	
NTPC	377.55	-4.52	14.75	1.58	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	249.00	-4.60	98.58	0.72	
Bajaj Auto	9776.00	-4.78	30.73	0.56	
Titan	4270.30	-5.18	79.54	1.56	
TCS	2613.50	-5.35	19.71	2.35	
Eternal Ltd.	242.87	-5.41	1014.62	1.54	
Tata Motors PV	370.60	-5.53	50.40	0.68	
Eicher Motors	7626.00	-5.57	40.07	0.95	
Bajaj Finserv	1941.90	-6.46	16.16	0.98	
Asian Paints	2307.10	-6.85	56.60	0.92	
Axis Bank	1372.30	-7.29	16.13	3.47	
ICICI Bank	1374.00	-7.68	17.35	8.66	
Adani Ports	1470.30	-8.21	27.11	0.96	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1062.50	-8.26	21.65	1.30	
Hdfcys	1288.90	-8.61	18.66	3.98	
Bajaj Finance	978.25	-10.28	33.22	2.49	
State Bank	1189.90	-10.74	12.69	4.36	
M&M	3334.30	-12.36	24.53	2.63	
Maruti Suzuki	14388.00	-13.50	30.30	1.67	
IntlGlobeAvi	4520.40	-15.22	54.43	0.90	
HDPC Bank	67.90	-28.02	17.47	11.87	
Reliance Ind	1590.20	-26.27	32.80	1.65	
L&T	4066.70	-54.52	29.48	4.21	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▼ 1,060.65 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Solar Industries	13989.00	35.45	82.91	1.49	
Vedanta	723.35	25.19	17.07	5.36	
Hindustanaeronautics	3561.60	21.86	29.71	3.28	
Hindalco Zinc	617.65	18.01	22.11	1.37	
Torrent Pharma	4369.20	11.27	65.09	2.00	
Siemens Energy India .	2972.70	11.09	89.62	1.15	
Shree Cement	26125.00	2.01	52.48	1.53	
Divis Lab	6403.50	-1.91	68.57	3.56	
Mazagon Dock	2209.80	-3.44	37.04	0.73	
ICI Lombard Gic	1895.50	-4.36	33.71	2.01	
Bajaj Housing Finance .	85.28	-4.94	28.68	0.35	
Lic	841.95	-4.96	10.42	0.82	
Jindal Steel	1237.80	-7.18	62.63	2.02	
Hyundai Motor India .	2148.00	-7.44	30.14	1.34	
Jsw Energy .	481.30	-10.38	32.31	1.13	
ZydusHesciences	906.90	-11.11	18.16	0.99	
United Spirits	1366.60	-12.58	57.79	1.76	
Abb India	5983.00	-14.16	75.18	1.37	
Bajaj Holdings	10695.00	-14.16	13.28	2.02	
Britannia Ind	5959.00	-15.39	59.40	3.07	
LtTimindtree	4404.40	-16.03	27.64	1.78	
Amruba Cements	490.75	-17.66	24.65	1.31	
Macrotech Developers .	1962.30	-18.61	28.94	1.19	
Avenuesuper	3902.50	-19.92	86.39	2.45	
Siemens	3341.60	-20.42	75.06	1.29	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	99.34	-22.57	18.53	0.78	
Pidilittind	1465.50	-24.69	64.45	1.99	
Varun Beverages .	445.30	-25.05	49.18	2.66	
Adani Power .	137.97	-25.33	23.55	2.38	
Df	590.20	-26.27	32.99	1.65	
Bosch	35730.00	-27.46	37.84	1.34	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	711.85	-27.50	101.04	2.14	
Havells	1354.00	-32.61	57.27	1.49	
Power Finance	406.20	-32.60	4.02	2.58	
Cholamandalam&Fin	1703.70	-34.39	29.66	3.15	
Punjab Natl Bank	903.55	-38.81	80.19	1.21	
Gail (India)	165.07	-36.09	12.61	1.95	
Info Edge I	998.50	-36.25	38.42	1.70	
Bank Of Baroda	315.20	-37.57	8.30	2.56	
Canara Bank	153.56	-38.54	7.56	2.26	
Tvs Motor Cmp .	3813.10	-39.87	59.33	3.91	
AdaniGreenenergy	903.55	-40.88	80.19	1.21	
Rural Elec	338.95	-40.66	5.18	1.85	
Adani Energy Solutions .	972.30	-40.85	49.00	1.47	
Indian Hotels Co .	651.00	-42.29	42.81	2.50	
Tata Power	368.35	-46.35	23.50	2.70	
Godrej Consumer	1176.00	-50.10	66.06	2.07	
Bpcl	374.80	-61.64	6.61	3.17	
Samvardhanamotherninternatl	128.65	-63.37	27.31	2.30	
Indian Oilcorp	179.11	-93.72	6.86	2.92	

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

RBI, Bank of Japan renew
bilateral swap deal



Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Bank of Japan (BoJ), which is acting as the agent for the Minister of Finance, Japan, have signed the third Amendment and Restatement Agreement of the Bilateral Swap Arrangement for up to \$75 billion. The BSA is effective February 28, 2026. **OUR BUREAU**

ASMS to acquire
minority stake in Huwel

Hyderabad: Avio Smart Market Stack (ASMS), formerly Bartronics India, has signed a share subscription-cum-shareholders' agreement with Huwel Lifesciences. Under the agreement, ASMS will acquire a minority stake in Huwel and collaborate on business development and project execution. **OUR BUREAU**

Factory output growth in January slows to three-month low of 4.8%

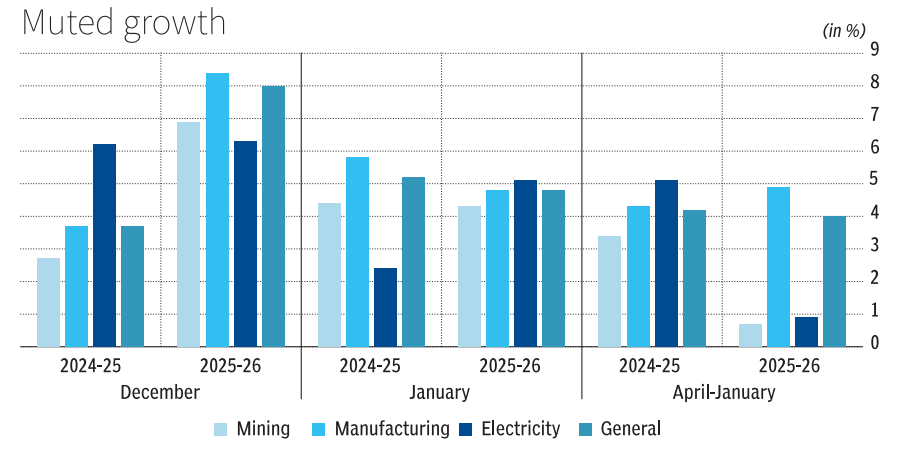
DECLINING TREND. Manufacturing, mining sector slowdown impacts performance

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

With manufacturing and mining showing subdued performance, growth of factory output, based on the Index of Industrial Production (IIP), dipped to a three-month low of 4.8 per cent in January, data from the Statistics Ministry released on Monday showed.

According to an official statement, industrial production growth for December 2025 was revised to 8 per cent from the provisional estimate of 7.8 per cent released in January 2026. Data further showed that the manufacturing sector's output growth decelerated to 4.8 per cent in January 2025, compared with 5.8 per cent in the year-ago month. Mining production growth also slowed marginally to 4.3 per cent (4.4 per cent).

Power generation grew 5.1 per cent in January 2025 (2.4 per cent). During the April-January period of FY26, in-



Source: MoSPI

dustrial production growth also slowed slightly to 4 per cent (4.2 per cent).

“The slowdown was broad-based across mining, manufacturing and electricity, with some base effects also contributing to the deceleration. However, growth across sectors remains steady,” said Rajani Sinha, Chief Economist with CareEdge. On the demand side,

consumer dynamics weakened, with consumer durables growth softening to 6.3 per cent (12.4 per cent) and non-durables slipping into contraction at 2.7 per cent (8.5 per cent).

USE-BASED FRONT

Even so, “the favourable impact of GST rate rationalisation and earlier RBI rate cuts is expected to continue sup-

porting consumption, going forward,” she said.

Aastha Gudwani, India Chief economist at Barclays, said sector-wise data showed broad-based moderation, with slower growth in manufacturing leading the deceleration in headline. “On the use-based front, barring infrastructure and construction goods, all other sub-categories saw slower growth

Fino Payments eyes SFB conversion before 18-month timeline

Piyush Shukla
Mumbai

Notwithstanding the arrest of its MD and CEO Rishi Gupta by GST authorities last week, Fino Payments Bank — basis its interaction with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) — expects to complete transitioning into a small finance bank (SFB) before the regulatory timeline of 18 months.

“This is something which is not a normal scenario, where a MD, CEO of the

bank is alleged for actions of program managers. In this regard, there have been various meetings that have happened across all levels in the RBI... As things stand now, there is no impact whatsoever on our SFB plans,” said Ketan Merchant, Fino PB CFO. The bank had, in December 2025, received the RBI's in-principle approval to convert to a SFB.

Merchant said that despite the recent adverse developments, deposits at the bank have remained intact or have rather grown from ₹2,250

crore as on February 26, when Gupta was arrested. He said the bank continues to open 10,000 low-cost deposit accounts on average each day, and its throughput continues to be around ₹1,300 crore per day.

Fino PB's Chief Business Officer Shailesh Pandey said the bank banned all merchants associated with on-line gambling platforms after the Centre banned the same in August 2025. Before the ban, the bank's 8-10 per cent of annual throughput was generated via merchants

associated with online betting apps, he said.

LEGAL ACTION

Fino's legal advisors have expressed positive view regarding legal tenability of Gupta's arrest and the matter will now proceed as per judicial process in Hyderabad, said Merchant.

“The bank does not directly or indirectly engage or promote any kind of betting activity through any forum, website, platform or in any form. Its program managers and merchant onboarding

process is in line with regulatory requirements and due process has been followed. Onboarding is done by concerned business relevant team and not by any individual,” he said.

As part of the onboarding checks, one of the pre-conditions is that the merchants referred by the program manager(s) need to have existing banking relationship with another bank for facilitating the UPI transactions. The bank does not maintain any current account of the program manager(s)/mer-

chants and the funds received through the VPA handle provided by the bank are subsequently settled to the designated bank accounts of the program managers/merchants with the respective public/private sector banks.

Fino does not see any financial liability at this point on account of this development and says that the alleged GST evasion was done by program managers and there is no onus on the bank to monitor the GST payment of program managers.

Mitsubishi Mahindra Agricultural Machinery to exit business, continue spare parts supply

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Mahindra & Mahindra (M&M) has announced that its Japan-based associate, Mitsubishi Mahindra Agricultural Machinery Co (MAM), will withdraw from the agricultural machinery business, while continuing to supply spare parts and provide warranty services.

All other operations will be formally wound down through liquidation procedures, planned for the first half of fiscal 2027.

The decision comes after years of underperformance and repeated efforts to restore profitability.

For the fiscal year ended March 31, 2025, MAM reported revenues of ₹2,094.17 crore, contributing ₹1,786.03 crore (1.13 per cent) to M&M's consolidated turnover.



PHASED PLAN. All other operations will be formally wound down through liquidation procedures, planned for the first half of fiscal 2027

The net worth of MAM as on March 31, 2025, was ₹17.74 crore, and after elimination of inter-company balances and adjustments with the Mahindra Group, it contributed 1.17 per cent of the consolidated profit after tax of the company.

was at ₹227.42 crore, and after elimination of inter-company balances and adjustments with the Mahindra Group, it contributed 1.17 per cent of the consolidated profit after tax of the company.

DECISION FACTORS

MAM's management said in a regulatory filing, “The company has pursued sustain-

able growth ... making continued efforts to expand into new markets. However, after comprehensively considering recent changes in the domestic and international industry environment and demand structure, as well as various constraints related to the production system and after carefully assessing the profitability of the business and its long-term sustainability over an extended period, the company has concluded that it would be difficult to continue the business sustainably.”

MAM, however, said that it would continue to supply spare parts for its products to existing customers.

For Mahindra, this exit allows sharper allocation of capital and management bandwidth toward higher-return segments, including electric mobility and farm mechanisation in India and other growth markets.

PE-VC deals pick up pace as late-stage investments increase

Our Bureau
Chennai

Private Equity-Venture Capital (PE-VC) investments saw a 27 per cent year-on-year rise in terms of value in February 2026. The value of PE-VC investments in February 2026 stood at \$2.6 billion across 108 deals as against \$1.9 billion investments across 94 deals in February of 2025, as per data from Venture Intelligence.

On a sequential basis, the value of investments were up from \$1.7 billion in January 2026 across 101 deals. The uptick in investments was driven by a more than 2x increase in late-stage deals, with \$910 million invested across 16 such deals (\$420 million across 18 deals).

Investments in early-stage firms stood at \$354 million across 61 deals, while growth-stage investments

went down to \$244 million across 25 deals. In terms of the deal size, mega deals (over \$100 million) saw a sharp rise with \$1.7 billion across seven such deals (\$1 billion). The average early-stage deal size doubled to \$6 million (\$3 million), while late stage increased to \$57 million (\$23 million). For the growth stage, it went down to \$10 million (\$14 million).

Arun Natarajan, Founder, Venture Intelligence, said that both foreign and homegrown PE investors confidentially pulled the trigger on large control/buy-out transactions in February.

The largest deal in the month was the \$600 million raised by AI acceleration cloud platform Neysa from Blackstone, TVS Capital, 360 ONE Assets, Nexus Ventures and Teachers' Venture Growth, among others.

Dabur to invest ₹60 crore in RAS Beauty

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Dabur India, through its investment platform Dabur Ventures, is acquiring a minority stake in RAS Beauty for ₹60 crore. This is the first investment of Dabur Ventures, which was established by the FMCG major in October last year with an allocation of ₹500 crore, to acquire stake in high-potential, new-age D2C businesses that are aligned with its long-term strategic vision.

“This investment will enable us to accelerate our omnichannel presence, deepen our R&D capabilities, and invest in brand and team building, all in pursuit of our long-term goal of making RAS a leading name in luxury skincare,” said Shubika Jain, Co-Founder & CEO, RAS Beauty.

Tata Steel to invest ₹11,000 cr in Jharkhand

Press Trust of India
Ranchi

Tata Steel will invest ₹11,000 crore in Jharkhand for developing advanced grade steel at its Jamshedpur facility, Tata Group Chairman N Chandrasekaran said on Monday. The technology developed by the Tata Group for advanced steel production will benefit other steel-makers, too, he said.

“Tata Steel will invest ₹11,000 crore in Jharkhand for developing advanced green steel technology, pioneered by it with low carbon production... It will make the steel process faster and reduce carbon emission,” Chandrasekaran said, sharing the stage with CEO TV Narendran and Chief Minister Hemant Soren.

The steel major has pioneered and developed the

technology, and its first investment will be in Jamshedpur, he said.

“It is a very important project for Tata Steel's footprint globally, and this technology will also benefit other steel companies,” he added.

Following successful pilot trials in the Netherlands, Tata Steel plans to establish a commercial-scale facility of around 1 million tonnes per annum capacity in Jamshedpur by 2030.

TATA MOTORS' PLANS

Besides, Tata Motors will also invest in hydrogen trucks at the Jamshedpur facility, Chandrasekaran added.

He also said the Tata Group will form an experts' panel to explore investment in various sectors for the development of Jharkhand, “as suggested by the Chief Minister”.

Manufacturing PMI rose to 4-month high in Feb

Our Bureau
New Delhi



With strong domestic demand, the manufacturing sector in India recorded its highest upturn in production volumes for four months in February, S&P Global reported on Monday. The Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) rose to a four-month high of 56.9 in the said month.

While manufacturing is considered an important source of job multiplier, job creation in the month was at a slower pace.

“India's final manufacturing PMI reflected an acceleration in manufacturing activity in February. Output expanded at a faster rate for a second month, supported by stronger domestic orders,” said Pranjul Bhandari, Chief India Economist at HSBC. However, new export orders continued the slowing trend that began in mid-2025, somewhat restricting employment creation in the manufacturing sector.

PMI Manufacturing is derived based on responses from purchasing managers of 400 companies. An index above 50 represents expansion, while below 50 means contraction.

According to the survey report, goods producers indicated that demand buoyancy, marketing initiatives and rising client requirements underpinned another expansion in new business intakes.

Moreover, the pace of growth was historically elevated and the strongest since last October. Output also rose at the fastest pace in four months, one that was above its long-run average.

OUTPUT VOLUMES

According to panel members, efficiency improvements, healthy underlying demand, rising intake of new work and tech investment

One area where growth took a step back was new export orders

collectively boosted production volumes.

“One area where growth took a step back was new export orders. February's increase was the slowest in 17 months, with the rate of expansion broadly converging towards its long-run average. Where external sales rose, monitored companies cited gains from Asia, Europe, West Asia and the US,” the report said.

On job creation, the report said that factory employment expanded only slightly, nevertheless at the quickest pace in four months.

“One factor that supported additional hiring was a further increase in outstanding business volumes at manufacturers in India. Although marginal, the rate of backlog accumulation strengthened to a seven-month high,” it said.

Looking ahead, the report highlighted that year-ahead assessments of output volumes remained positive as 16 per cent of companies forecast growth and fewer than 1 per cent anticipate a reduction.

“Boding well for the outlook were marketing efforts and favourable demand conditions, qualitative survey data showed,” it added.

India's Q3 CAD widens to \$13.2 b on higher trade deficit, net FDI outflows

Our Bureau
Mumbai

India's current account deficit (CAD) widened to \$13.2 billion in the third quarter (Q3FY26) from the year-ago quarter's \$11.3 billion due to factors such as higher merchandise trade deficit (MTD) and net outflows under foreign direct investment (FDI). The CAD in the reporting quarter was also wider than the preceding quarter's \$12.3 billion.

In percentage terms, the Q3FY26 CAD increased to 1.3 per cent of GDP (1.1 per cent). However, CAD in the reporting quarter was unchanged from the preceding quarter.

Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist, ICRA, observed that India's CAD widened to \$13.2 billion in Q3FY26 (\$11.3 billion), while printing well below ICRA's fore-



cast of \$20 billion for the quarter. The undershooting was largely led by lower-than-expected MTD as well as primary income outflows.

“Looking ahead, the unusually higher-than-expected MTD for January 2026 is likely to limit the seasonal improvement in the current account balance in Q4 FY26, unless the prints for February and March 2026 cool significantly,” she added.

Additionally, the recent surge in international crude oil prices, following the conflict in West Asia, is also

likely to have some bearing on the import bill in the immediate term. ICRA currently expects the current account balance to print between “-\$1.0 billion and +\$1.0 billion” in Q4FY26.

“We estimate India's current account deficit to print at 0.6-0.7 per cent of GDP in FY26, and rise thereafter to around 1 per cent of GDP in FY27, albeit with risks tilted to the upside,” Nayar said.

MTD in the reporting quarter was higher at \$ 93.6 billion (\$79.3 billion).

Net services receipts increased to \$57.5 billion in Q3FY26 (\$51.2 billion). Services exports have risen on a year-on-year basis in major categories such as computer services and other business services, RBI said in a statement. Net outgo on the primary income account, mainly reflecting payments of investment income, de-

creased to \$12.2 billion in Q3 (\$16.4 billion). Personal transfer receipts under secondary income account, mainly representing remittances by Indians employed overseas, rose to \$36.9 billion in Q3 (\$35.1 billion).

INFLOW, OUTFLOW

Foreign direct investment recorded a net outflow of \$3.7 billion in Q3 (\$2.8 billion). Foreign portfolio investment recorded a net outflow of \$0.2 billion in Q3 (\$11.4 billion).

Net inflows under external commercial borrowings to India was lower at \$3.3 billion in Q3 (\$4.4 billion). Non-resident deposits recorded higher inflows of \$5.1 billion (\$3.1 billion). There was a depletion of \$24.4 billion in the foreign exchange reserves (on a Balance of Payments basis) in Q3 (\$37.7 billion).

36 Maharatna, Navratna PSUs face board governance gaps: Survey

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Several of India's largest public sector utilities (PSUs) continue to run with gaps in board composition, evaluation and governance processes, according to a survey by Excellence Enablers. The study found that 36 Maharatna and Navratna companies did not have the prescribed minimum number of independent directors in FY25. Board diversity also remained uneven, with 17 companies having no women directors on their boards, indicating ongoing gaps in compliance with governance norms.

Independent directors are expected to play a key role in strengthening board oversight and protecting minority shareholder interests. A shortage of such directors



could weaken supervision at large listed companies, particularly in public sector enterprises where government ownership is significant.

Only 13 companies conducted board evaluations in FY24 and FY25, and only one evaluated all required categories, including the board, individual directors, the chairperson and board committees.

RED FLAGS

Whistleblower mechanisms also appeared largely inactive. Of the 31 companies that

disclosed complaint data, 28 reported zero whistleblower complaints in FY25. While this may reflect fewer internal issues, the report suggests that companies should ensure their reporting systems are credible and accessible. The report also flagged participation and accountability at the board level. “It is a legitimate expectation that every Director, executive or non-executive, attends every meeting of the Board of Directors,” it said.

Audit oversight may also need strengthening at large State-run enterprises. “The regulatory prescription that the Audit Committee shall meet at least four times in a year is clearly inadequate,” the report said, arguing that companies of such scale and complexity require deeper scrutiny of financial and risk matters.

QUICKLY.

Wheat, corn rise on safe-haven buying



Hamburg: Chicago wheat and corn rose on Monday as the outbreak of military conflict in the Middle East sparked safe-haven demand. Soybeans, meanwhile, fell on weak market fundamentals. Chicago Board of Trade's most-active wheat rose 0.8 per cent to \$5.96 a bushel at 1145 GMT. Corn rose 0.1 per cent to \$4.49, while soybeans fell 0.1 per cent to \$11.68-1/2 a bushel. REUTERS

Palm oil gains on Chicago, crude supports

Jakarta: Malaysian palm oil futures hit a one-week high and closed higher for a second straight session, tracking gains in Chicago edible oils. The benchmark palm oil contract for May delivery on the BMD gained 104 ringgit to 4,146 ringgit (\$1,056.57) a tonne. REUTERS

Supply concerns boost aluminium to 30-day high



London: Aluminium prices rose to their highest in more than a month on Monday after US and Israeli strikes in Iran fuelled concerns about prolonged conflict in the Middle East, a major producer of the metal. Benchmark aluminium on the LME was up 3.1 per cent at \$3,236 a tonne at 1050 GMT. Copper firmed 0.2 per cent to \$13,370; zinc gained 1 per cent to \$3,351. REUTERS

Gold, silver prices soar as war rattles West Asia

REGAINING SHEEN. Haven demand revives as gold tops \$5,375/oz and silver pares gains after surging to near \$95/oz

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

Gold and silver prices gained in global and domestic markets on Monday as the US-backed Israel war with Iran revived haven demand. In the global market, gold topped \$5,375 an ounce, while silver almost hit \$95 an ounce before paring gains.

Gold prices opened on a firm note in the Mumbai spot market in India. They gained ₹8,374 at ₹1,67,471 per 10 g against ₹1,59,097 during the weekend.

On MCX, gold for April delivery increased by ₹6,994 or four per cent to ₹1,69,098 per 10 g against the previous close of ₹1,62,104 on Friday. The June contract surged to ₹1,72,753 against ₹1,65,659 on Friday.

Silver prices soared by ₹23,148 to ₹2,89,848 per 1 kg against ₹266,700 on Friday. In the global market, gold was quoted at \$5,365.99 an ounce after nearing \$5,400 an ounce.

Silver ruled at \$92.04 an ounce.

Globally, COMEX gold advanced by 3 per cent to the session's peak of \$5,410 a troy ounce, while silver jumped 4 per cent to an intra-day high of \$97.3 per ounce amid escalating hostilities in West Asia.

STRONG UPTREND

The demand for haven investments such as gold and silver swelled as the war impact spread across West Asia including Dubai, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Lebanon, Bahrain, Oman and Qatar.

Prithviraj Kothari, President, India Bullion and Jewellers Association, said gold and silver remain in a struc-



RISK HEDGE. Precious metals remain in a strong structural uptrend, supported by geopolitical tensions, elevated global debt and expectations of accommodative monetary policy

turally strong uptrend, supported by geopolitical uncertainty, elevated global debt and expectations of accommodative monetary policy.

With tensions in West Asia intensifying and energy prices rising, safe-haven demand for gold continues to build.

As long as gold sustains above the \$5,200 zone, the momentum favours a move toward \$5,450-5,600 in the near term, he said.

Escalating war-like developments across the Middle East have intensified safe-haven demand, keeping bullion firmly bid despite already elevated levels, said Jateen N Trivedi, V-P, Currency and Commodity Research at LKP Securities.

Meanwhile, silver is benefiting from a persistent multi-year supply deficit, strong demand from solar, EVs, and AI infrastructure, and renewed investment flows are tightening the market. After breaking above \$95, silver has opened the

path toward \$100-105 levels, he said.

Kaynat Chainwala, AVP Commodity Research, Kotak Securities, said heightened geopolitical tensions in West Asia pushed precious metals sharply higher, with both Comex gold and silver hitting a fresh one-month highs. Looking ahead, bullion is likely to remain supported as Trump indicated that military operations could extend for "four to five weeks", he said.

Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, said the broader bullish structure remains intact in Comex silver with prices reclaiming major moving averages, signalling a transition from correction to renewed strength toward \$110-115 an ounce.

MCX silver futures may continue to extend their rally as it finds support at ₹250,000-270,000 and a sustained hold above this level could trigger recovery toward ₹320,000-330,000 per 10 g.

US-Iran war leaves 70,000 tonnes of basmati to Gulf stuck on high seas

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Basmati exporters, who were pinning their hopes on registering record-high exports this fiscal year, are now praying for an early end to the war. Industry officials noted that the conflict has disrupted shipments to West Asia, a key market for the aromatic rice, with an estimated 60,000-70,000 tonnes currently on the high seas, some of which are near the Bandar Abbas port.

During the April-January period of 2025-26, 5.38 million tonnes (mt) of basmati rice were exported — an 11 per cent increase over the 4.84 mt recorded in the same period last year, according to Satish Goel, President of the All-India Rice Exporters Association (AIREA).

"We were on target to

achieve a record 6.5 mt of basmati export this year, but for this war. If it ends in a week, it is still possible to meet the target; it will be difficult," Goel said, adding that exporters are scheduled to meet the Apeda Chairman and other officials on Tuesday to discuss potential outcomes and how the government might provide support.

When asked about the quantity currently stuck at sea, he mentioned that the association is still assessing the figures with the government, though he added it is possible that 60,000 to 70,000 tonnes are affected.

Goel said that while there has been no increase in shipping charges so far, the situation remains so fluid that it is impossible to predict what will happen next.

TARN TARAN SUFFERS

Sources at Apeda said they

are attempting to assist exporters reaching out to them, as the crisis is impacting all products, including agriculture.

"Basmati rice export from Tarn Taran and surrounding areas has been completely disrupted due to the eruption of war during the month of Ramzan," said Ashok Sethi, Director of the Punjab Rice Millers Exporters Association. He said the majority of the industry players in this region, which dominates due to its excellent quality, usually export 70 per cent of their basmati to West Asian countries.

Punjab rice exporters fear delayed payments as a large number of shipments are being held at Indian ports or are stranded en route, potentially missing delivery schedules for Ramadan.

Sethi said the association has sought the Central Gov-

ernment's assistance for the basmati industry.

ACTIVE BUYING

Former AIREA President Vijay Setia noted that Iran bought rice actively over the past two months, likely in anticipation of a conflict. Consequently, basmati prices increased by ₹10-15 a kg due to Iranian demand.

"Shipping liners have announced *force majeure*. The Government should issue a directive to container companies not to penalise exporters or impose charges for delay (in emptying containers)," Setia said, adding that ships are also taking U-turns or being rerouted, resulting in delayed deliveries.

BV Krishna Rao, President of The Rice Exporters Association, confirmed that rice exports to the Gulf will be hampered by the stand-off with Iran.

Pistachios, figs & raisins to become pricey

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Indian consumers may have to pay more for their pistachios, raisins and figs, while walnuts will likely remain stable for another couple of months on account of ample stocks in view of the current Gulf crisis.

"India gets pistachios from Iran and California (US). With Iranian supplies cut off, prices have gone up by ₹100 a kg," said Gunjan Jain, President, Nuts and Dried Fruits Council of India (NDFC-I).

Iran's shipments have been affected after the Bandar Abbas and Chabahar ports were closed, following the outbreak of hostilities between Iran and the US-Israel axis.

The US and Israel have targeted Tehran and killed its President Ayotollah Ali Khamanei. In retaliation, Iran struck various American interests in the Gulf region, particularly the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia.

HOLI HOLIDAYS

"The problem for imports of dry fruits by India is that consignments from Afghanistan have already been affected after the India-Pakistan stand-off last year. Sea was the only route, but the closure of Bandar Abbas and Chabahar will totally affect supplies," said Jain.

Raju Bhatia of the International Nut and Dried Fruit Council said the North Indian market, particularly New Delhi, was slightly better, with the impact being less due to holidays on the



eve of the *Holi* festival.

"There are 3-4 days of holidays this week, with *Holi* falling on Wednesday. Hopefully, better sense will prevail (in the international community to end the stalemate)," he said.

In Delhi, prices of pistachios have increased by ₹40-50 a kg, since India depends a lot on Iranian pistachios.

Before the Gulf crisis emerged, pistachio kernels ruled at around ₹1,500-1,600

a kg on e-commerce websites.

Pistachio in shell were quoted around ₹1,200-1,300 a kg. Jain said prices of figs have also increased by ₹100 a kg on Monday, while Bhatia did not give any figure in view of the market being closed in Delhi.

"Figs have to come from Afghanistan and its shipments could be affected by the current crisis," said the NDFC-I president.

WALNUT TO BE STABLE

Raisin prices will likely increase as they usually come from Afghanistan, with Indian arrivals getting over.

However, walnut prices will remain stable as traders have ample stocks. "There are no worries over the availability of walnuts as supplies are ample," said Jain.

Sugar exports may drop, easing concerns over domestic supplies

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

If the notional sugar stocks reported by mills to the government are accurate, India may face tight supplies this year. Production is now projected to fall below initial estimates, leaving limited availability to meet demand in the first two months of the next season.

However, the US-Israel attack on Iran and subsequent tensions could sharply curb shipments to key Gulf markets, helping ease domestic availability.

The government permitted exports of 2 million tonnes (mt) in two tranches for the current season (October 2025-September 2026). Industry experts, however, expect shipments to be capped around 0.5 mt, effectively retaining about 1.5 mt in the country at a time the



MARKET SHIFT. The war and subsequent tensions could curb shipments to key Gulf markets, helping ease domestic availability

production outlook remains weak. Sugar mills reported stocks of about 12.05 mt as of February 28. Domestic production reached 24.63 mt by that date, up from 22.01 mt a year earlier, according to data from the National Federation of Cooperative Sugar Factories Ltd (NFCFSF).

LESS CARRY-OVER

The Indian Sugar & Bio-en-

ergy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) has pegged net sugar production for the year at 29.29 mt (after ethanol diversion). This implies an additional 4.66 mt of output by September 30.

Combined with existing stocks, this would ensure availability of about 16.71 mt during March-September. Compared with the 16.1 mt allocated during the same

period last year, the surplus available for carry-forward appears marginal.

Industry veteran GK Sood, however, questioned the stock figures. "The notional stock appears understated when seen against domestic allocation of 11.05 mt, production of 24.63 mt during October-February and an opening balance of 4.7 mt," he said. Even so, he said the overall balance remains tight, though imports may not be necessary.

The key risk now is whether net production holds at the estimated 29.3 mt or slips further. Sood said output could fall closer to 28 mt. Government allocations also signal caution.

Domestic release for October-March 2025-26 has been set at 13.3 mt, lower than 13.75 mt a year ago. The March quota has been fixed at 2.25 mt, compared with 2.3 mt last year.

It is *déjà vu* for the cashew industry

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi



Escalating tensions in West Asia have pushed India's cashew industry into *déjà vu*, disrupting logistics, payments and key export markets.

J Rajmohan Pillai, Chairman and Managing Director of Beta Group, which owns the NutKing brand, said Iran had emerged as a key growth market for Indian cashews in recent years, with trade often routed through hubs such as Dubai.

However, since hostilities intensified in early 2026, shipments worth hundreds of crores of rupees have been stranded.

Iranian buyers have largely stopped placing fresh orders following the closure of major ports, including Bandar Abbas, and the freezing of banking channels.

Iran was a key buyer of premium grades such as W180 and W210. Its sudden exit has created a temporary

glut of high-quality kernels in India.

Traders report sharp wholesale price volatility, with domestic prices softening as exporters try to liquidate stocks originally meant for Tehran, he said. The industry's reliance on UAE-based payment routes for Iranian trade has now turned into a liability.

With military strikes reported near regional hubs, the financial bridge that enabled such transactions has effectively collapsed, Pillai added. Even as India faces disruptions, processors in Vietnam are aggressively targeting the US and China, intensifying competition and

Tensions may hit tea shipments

V Sajeew Kumar
Vishwanath Kulkarni
Kochi/Bengaluru

Tea exporters are on edge as escalating tensions in the Middle East threaten supply chains to key Gulf markets. Restrictions on shipping and air movements have disrupted deliveries across several destinations.

Cherian George, Chairman of the Tea Committee, UPASI, said the intensifying conflict raised concerns about prolonged instability in the region, which accounts for nearly 45-50 per cent of tea exports. "There is currently no contact with Iran, and the situation remains delicate. Fortunately, the season is ending and availability is limited. But if the crisis persists beyond a month, it will impact exports and prices," said Anish

Bhansali, partner at Bhansali & Co, a major exporter.

Bhansali said many exporters have outstanding payments for earlier shipments, and the deteriorating situation has increased uncertainty over recoveries.

In 2025, India shipped significant volumes to Middle East markets, including Iraq (52.59 million kg), the UAE (52.71 million kg), Iran (11.25 million kg) and Saudi Arabia (7.94 million kg), underscoring the region's strategic importance.

ROUTE INSTABILITY

George, also CEO and Whole-Time Director of Harrison's Malayalam Ltd, said shipping lines may be forced to reroute cargo via the Cape of Good Hope instead of the Suez Canal. This would add over 3,500 nautical miles and more than 25 days to transit time, poten-

tially pushing freight costs up by as much as 40 per cent and hurting the competitiveness of Indian tea.

Dipak Shah, Chairman of the South India Tea Exporters Association, said the crisis is affecting shipments not only to West Asia but also Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Uzbekistan that depend on the same trade routes.

"It's too early to assess the impact as the duration of the conflict is uncertain," said N Lakshmanan Chettiar of Golden Hills Estate, Coonoor, adding that Middle East buyers may be absent at upcoming Kochi auctions.

"There is no clarity on the situation in Iran, so the industry has to wait and watch," said Anshuman Kanoria, Chairman of the Indian Tea Exporters Association.

With inputs from Mithun Dasgupta in Kolkata

Brewing crisis in promising Gulf export market leaves poultry industry worried

KV Kurmanath
Vishwanath Kulkarni
Prabhudatta Mishra
Hyderabad/Bengaluru/New Delhi

The sudden escalation of tensions in the Gulf following the US-Iran conflict has come as a shock to the poultry industry.

The concern is evident as exports to the United Arab Emirates this year surged to \$93 million — more than three times the \$24 million recorded in the same period last year.

In the first nine months of 2025-26, shipments nearly doubled to a record \$237 million, compared with \$119 million a year earlier, according to data from the Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and



Statistics (DGCIS).

LIMITED IMPACT

Despite the spike in exports, the overseas segment remains small compared with the industry's overall size of about \$30 billion.

With the sector growing at 7-8 per cent annually, the Gulf conflict is unlikely to materially affect overall in-

dustry growth. The industry is, however, closely monitoring the developments, even as most egg and egg product shipments were completed ahead of the peak Ramadan demand.

In key West Asian markets such as the UAE, Oman and Saudi Arabia, Indian exporters face competition from Iran and Turkey, which enjoy a price advantage due to proximity and lower production costs.

FRESH DEMAND

"We are closely watching supply chains from competing origins such as Iran and Turkey, which supply a significant share of poultry products to West Asia," said Valsan Parameswaran, Secretary, All India Poultry Exporters Association.

The volatile situation may not hurt India's poultry exports significantly. Any disruption in supplies from Iran or Turkey could, in fact, create fresh demand for Indian eggs and egg products.

Falling domestic egg prices during the summer are also expected to improve India's competitiveness in West Asian markets, Parameswaran said.

While the industry remains cautious about short-term disruptions, it also sees a potential upside. Oman, a key market, remains largely unaffected.

"It could actually turn into an opportunity as any disruption in supplies from Brazil may allow India to fill the gap," said Srinivas Chituri, Managing Director, Srinivasa Farms.

Zinc prices remain higher but seem to be struggling to stage a strong rise. The zinc futures contract traded on the Multi-Commodity Exchange has been facing strong resistance in the ₹330-335 per kg region for about a month now. The contract is currently trading at ₹328 per kg.

The broader outlook is positive. The price action since the beginning of February indicates a consolidation. Near-term support is at ₹324. Below that, ₹318 is the next important support. Resistance is in the ₹330-335 region.

A narrow trading range of ₹324-335 is possible for some time now. A decisive break above ₹335 is needed to boost the bullish momentum. Such a break could trigger a fresh rally to ₹355-360 in the coming weeks.

On the other hand, if the contract breaks below ₹324, it could fall to ₹318.

For now, we will have wait and watch for a breakout on either side of ₹324-335 to get clarity on the next leg of move.

TRADE STRATEGY

Traders can go long only on a break above ₹335. Keep the stop-loss at ₹327. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹339 as soon as the contract goes up to ₹344. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹343 and ₹348 when the price touches ₹347 and ₹351, respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹355.



Dr. Rakesh Kumar is a senior research fellow at the Centre for Policy Studies, Indian Institute of Management, Ahmedabad. He is also an adjunct professor at the Indian Institute of Management, Bangalore. He has been a faculty member at the Indian Institute of Management, Ahmedabad, for over 20 years. He has published several research papers in the area of corporate governance and has been a frequent speaker at various conferences and seminars. He is also a member of the National Institute of Advanced Studies, Bangalore.

Mumbai: MedGenome, a genomics diagnostics and research services company, has made a majority investment in Mumbai's Medicare Management Services — a radiology and nuclear medicine provider, for an undisclosed sum. Medicare has four fully integrated imaging facilities at Chembur, Goregaon, Andheri and Navi Mumbai. OUR BUREAU



“Several customers are opting to return to India via Oman. However, the challenge is getting seat on flights as they are full. One of

“At ixigo, we are actively monitoring the evolving situation and issuing regular travel advisories with real time airline and airport operations updates to help our customers stay informed. To better support our customers during this period, we have initiated proactive Voice AI calling for those whose travel plans may be affected, offering timely information and assistance with changes or alternatives,” ixigo said.

"I believe I still have some years left to give back to Airtel and Bharti Enterprises but the next generation of my family are all building muscle in different forms and shapes. I think in a few

Satish Mehta, Emcure Managing Director and Chief Executive, said the companies would together expand access to these critical therapies and support physicians in delivering care to patients across India.

Mittal said some of the friendly investors were not happy when Airtel decided to start operations in Africa in 2010 and now Airtel Africa is a star performer and helped Indian operations during the difficult period of 2016-19 for the telecom sector.

STRONG SUBSIDIARY
“Airtel Africa in the next few years is poised to be a \$10 billion revenue company generating upwards of \$5 billion and a very strong subsidiary of Airtel India generating very handsome returns for the company,” Mittal said.

Talking about Airtel in India, Mittal said that 8-9 years ago he had advocated for ARPU (average revenue per

"I am not counting all the inflation that has taken place in the last eight or nine years. ₹300 is now 15 per cent away from where Airtel is today. When will it happen? I don't know but it will certainly get there. Is it a matter of months or is it a matter of a year or two."

He said that free unlimited data on 5G may need to be bundled into a more coherent way than the current plans.

"I see no reason why heavy consumers, business users and high-end users should be paying only ₹400 a month which as you know is now nearly about four dollars a month. A dollar or two more to provide them these high-quality, high-bandwidth services is the legitimate expectation we have."

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